WORKING DRAFT · FOR AUTHOR REVIEW

LETTERS CONFLICT

ORIGINS

The Anatomy of the Conflict

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Chapters 1–11 · Draft · 2026-10-31

A Note to the Reader

This book is a history written as literature. It moves between documented events and reflection, between stone and story, and you deserve to know at every point which is which.

Four kinds of material appear in these pages.

Established history — conclusions strongly supported by archaeology, written records or careful scholarship. These carry a number in square brackets that leads to the Research Notes and Sources at the back of the book.

Scholarly debate — questions on which serious historians disagree. Where they do, the book says so and names the positions rather than quietly choosing the most dramatic one.

Oral tradition — accounts carried across generations by speech, song and teaching. They are treated as living evidence, with attention to who carries them, when they were recorded and how they have changed.

The author's interpretation — the meaning I draw from the evidence. The central image of this trilogy, that people are letters and institutions are grammar, belongs here. It is a way of seeing, not a historical finding.

Illustrations introduced with "imagine" or "suppose" are teaching devices, not reports. No quotation, conversation or private thought has been invented for a historical person. Where a scene is reconstructed from the record, the text says so.

Africa is not one country, one people or one story. Wherever it matters, this book names the society, the region and the century.

The prose carries the story. The notes carry the evidence. Read the first for the journey; consult the second whenever you want to check the road.

Chapter 1

The Story Before the Wound

> *"Until the lions have their own historians, the history of the hunt will always glorify the hunter."*
>
> — Proverb, as cited by Chinua Achebe

In 1871 a German geologist named Karl Mauch walked into a valley in what is now south-eastern Zimbabwe. He was looking for gold. What he found was stone.

On a granite hill stood walls fitted without mortar, course laid upon course, following the shapes of the boulders as though the rock itself had been persuaded to rise. In the valley below, a great curving wall enclosed an open space and a tall conical tower. The walls of that enclosure reach more than ten metres in height and run for some 250 metres. The people who raised them had split granite from the surrounding hills into even blocks and stepped each course slightly back from the one beneath it, so that the whole structure leans gently inward and holds itself up. [1] The Shona word *Zimbabwe* is usually rendered "house in stone". [2]

Mauch looked at the walls and saw the Bible. The ruins, he decided, were the palace of the Queen of Sheba, raised in the land of Ophir in imitation of Solomon's temple. When he examined a wooden beam set into one of the walls, he concluded that it was cedar, that cedar meant Lebanon, and that Phoenician traders must have carried it south. [3]

He did not conclude that the people farming that valley might be descended from the builders. In his judgement the walls were too accomplished to be theirs.

This book begins with that judgement. Not because Mauch was important — he was one traveller among many — but because his mistake holds the whole problem in miniature. The evidence stood in front of him. He touched it, measured it and drew it. And still the story he told about it had been decided before he arrived.

The walls did not change. The story around them did.

The question this trilogy follows is a large one. How did societies that built so much — cities, kingdoms, scholarship, law and long-distance trade — arrive at a present in which so many of their institutions struggle to turn human ability into shared progress? That question cannot be asked honestly until a smaller one has been answered first. Who has been telling the story, and what did they need it to say?

A Century of Argument Around a Wall

After Mauch, Great Zimbabwe became more than a ruin. It became an argument, and the argument became political.

In 1891 the English traveller Theodore Bent excavated at the site. His work, like that of the man who followed him, was sponsored by Cecil Rhodes, whose British South Africa Company was then taking control of the territory. [3] Bent credited the building to peoples from outside Africa, the "Semites" or "Hamites" of the racial vocabulary of his day. [4] The conclusion was convenient. A land whose greatest monument had been built by ancient outsiders could be presented as a land waiting for modern outsiders to return.

In 1902 Richard Nicklin Hall was engaged to examine and preserve the ruins on behalf of the new colonial government. He spent two years at the work. His own account, published in 1905, records the method: from each enclosure his workers removed "all débris and fallen stones to a depth of from 4 ft. to 7 ft." [5]

To an archaeologist, soil is an archive. Layers of earth record the order in which people lived, built, cooked, traded and left. Objects found in sequence can tell a story that no single object can. Hall believed the original builders were ancient and foreign, and he regarded much of what lay above the old floors as the debris of later, lesser occupation. Of some walls he wrote: "Some are constructions by indigenous peoples, and certainly they are not ancient." [5] In clearing the site he shovelled away a great

part of the sequence that could have answered the very question he believed he was settling. [4]

The correction came from professional archaeology. In 1905 the archaeologist David Randall-MacIver concluded that the buildings were African and medieval. In 1929 the British Association for the Advancement of Science invited Gertrude Caton-Thompson to investigate. She confirmed Randall-MacIver's conclusion that the ruins belonged to an indigenous African culture and found evidence of their links with Indian Ocean trade. [6] Her book *The Zimbabwe Culture* appeared in 1931. [4]

The evidence was now settled among specialists. The argument was not. The archaeologist Shadreck Chirikure describes how trained researchers supported a local origin while state-sponsored amateurs went on insisting that Great Zimbabwe was foreign. [4]

In 1965 Ian Smith's government declared Rhodesia independent of Britain in order to preserve white minority rule. [3] The old question returned with new force. In 1966 a member of the ruling party's executive was appointed to the Historical Monuments Commission. In 1968 and again in 1969 the national Censorship Board indicated that it intended to have museum displays on Zimbabwe altered. In 1969 a minister instructed that information on the site's origins should "indicate quite clearly that, as yet, no irrefutable evidence is available." [7]

Peter Garlake, who had served as the country's Inspector of Monuments since 1964 and whose research identified the builders as ancestors of the Shona, left Rhodesia in 1970. [8] Other professionals resigned, among them Roger Summers. [7] A new official guidebook was prepared. When the editors of the archaeological journal *Antiquity* examined it in 1974, they found material on psychic experiences, dowsing and Phoenician colonisation, and judged that it could be considered "unacceptable and even a little shaming." [7]

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

It is often said that the Rhodesian government banned archaeologists from saying that Africans built Great Zimbabwe. The record is more complicated, and more instructive.

Writing in 1974, Garlake himself said that he knew of no evidence that archaeological material had been censored, and had never claimed it. [7] Scholars could still publish in learned journals. The pressure fell elsewhere: on the guidebooks, museum displays and official statements through which ordinary citizens and schoolchildren met the past.

Nobody needed to deny the evidence. It was enough to insist that the question remained open, and to set dowsers beside archaeologists as though they were equal witnesses.

That is a lesson this book will need again. A false story does not always require a lie. Sometimes it requires only a false balance, repeated in the places where most people learn what they know.

On 18 April 1980 the Republic of Zimbabwe was proclaimed. Its new flag carried the Zimbabwe Bird, a figure taken from the soapstone carvings found at the site. [9] A nation took the name of the place whose builders it had been told were strangers, and put their work on its flag.

The walls had waited more than five centuries. They had outlasted Mauch, Bent and Hall, the colonial company and the government that tried to keep their question open. What they could not do on their own was teach the next generation what they meant. Stone survives. Understanding has to be handed on.

The Philosopher, the Explorer and the Professor

Great Zimbabwe was not an isolated misunderstanding. It was one local expression of a larger idea: that Africa stood outside history altogether.

In the 1820s the German philosopher Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel lectured in Berlin on the philosophy of world history. He had never set foot in Africa. In the translated text of those

lectures he dismisses the continent in two sentences: “At this point we leave Africa, not to mention it again. For it is no historical part of the World; it has no movement or development to exhibit.” [10]

Hegel was not reporting evidence. He was assigning Africa a place in a system he had already built, in which history meant the progress of a particular kind of state toward a particular kind of freedom. Whoever did not fit the system was declared to have no history at all.

Later in the century Hegel’s abstraction acquired a popular name. In 1878 the explorer Henry Morton Stanley published the account of his crossing of the continent under the title *Through the Dark Continent*. [11] “Dark” had once meant little more than unknown to European maps. The literary scholar Patrick Brantlinger has traced how, across the Victorian decades, the word came to mean something else: a moral and racial darkness that imperial rule promised to illuminate. [12] The phrase justified conquest by describing the conquered as people without light.

The irony sits inside Stanley’s own journey. In 1875 he reached the court of Kabaka Mutesa I of Buganda, on the northern shores of Lake Victoria: a kingdom with its own ruler, chiefs, capital and remembered history, whose story belongs to Chapter 5. From there he published an appeal for Christian missionaries to be sent to Buganda, and the Church Missionary Society began its Uganda mission two years later. [13] The traveller who called a continent dark had sat in the court of an organised African state.

The word outlived the journey. In time, many Africans would learn to describe their own past with it.

More than a century later the idea was still alive in one of the most prestigious chairs in the English-speaking world. In 1963 Hugh Trevor-Roper, Regius Professor of Modern History at Oxford, told a BBC audience: “Perhaps in the future, there will be some African history to teach. But, at present there is none: there is only the history of the Europeans in Africa. The rest is darkness…” [14]

He was wrong, and by then the proof was already in print. Seven years earlier the Nigerian historian Kenneth Onwuka Dike had published *Trade and Politics in the Niger Delta, 1830–1885*. Dike placed African traders, rulers and communities at the centre of their own history and combined written documents with oral evidence to do it. His work helped found what became known as the Ibadan school of African history. [15]

In 1964, the year after Trevor-Roper's broadcast, UNESCO launched the *General History of Africa*, a project that would draw on hundreds of African and international scholars and approach the continent's past from African perspectives. [16] Its first volume, edited by the Burkinabè historian Joseph Ki-Zerbo and published in 1981, did not begin with kings or conquests. It began with method: how African history can be known at all. [16]

The Nigerian novelist Chinua Achebe once cited a proverb that sums up what was at stake: until the lions have their own historians, the history of the hunt will always glorify the hunter. [17]

But the proverb carries a warning for the lions too. A history written by the hunted can also flatter its tellers. It can turn every ancestor into a hero, every kingdom into a paradise and every difficulty into someone else's fault. Replacing an insulting story with a flattering one does not complete the work of history. It only changes who is being flattered.

The task of this book is harder than reversing Hegel. It is to let African societies appear as they were: makers and borrowers, builders and conquerors, scholars and slave-holders, people capable of wisdom and of error, like human beings everywhere. We do our ancestors little honour by making them too perfect to have lived.

Three Witnesses

How, then, do we know anything about the African past? Through three kinds of witness, each with its own strengths and its own blind spots.

The stone. Archaeology reads the material world: walls, floors, tools, seeds, bones and the layers of earth that hold them. It is the witness that Hall's workmen silenced, and it keeps speaking where it is allowed to. At Great Zimbabwe, for example, the finding of sixteenth-century Chinese porcelain in the Valley Enclosures and newer radiocarbon dating have shown that the city did not simply collapse around 1450, as was long believed, but ebbed and flowed into the seventeenth century. [4] Even settled conclusions get revised when the stone is read more carefully.

The page. Written records — chronicles, letters, contracts, legal opinions, travellers' accounts — give us names, dates and arguments. Africa produced many of them, in Ge'ez, Arabic, Ajami and other scripts, and the manuscripts of Timbuktu will occupy us in Chapter 3. But a page records what someone chose to write. A law tells us what a ruler intended, not whether it was obeyed. A traveller's account tells us what a visitor noticed, and sometimes what he expected to find.

The voice. Much African history was carried by speech: genealogies, praise poetry, clan histories, songs and the teaching of elders. The Belgian historian Jan Vansina, who spent much of his career studying the kingdoms of Central Africa, helped make the use of oral tradition as historical evidence a subject of careful method. [18] Such accounts preserve knowledge that no excavation could recover. They also change as they pass from one teller to the next, and they serve the communities that carry them. So we ask of them what we should ask of any witness: who is speaking, from whom did they learn it, when was it written down, and do other tellers say something different?

No witness is complete. The stone has no words. The page has an author with interests. The voice has travelled through many mouths. History is the work of letting the three cross-examine one another.

Beyond the Wall

Return for a moment to the valley Mauch entered. The question he got wrong was “Who built this?” But even the right answer — the ancestors of the Shona — can hide almost everyone involved.

A wall like the Great Enclosure is not built by a name. Someone had to learn how granite splits. Someone had to quarry it, carry it and set it. Someone had to grow the grain and keep the cattle that fed the builders. Traders carried gold from the interior toward the coast; coins from Kilwa, glass beads and Chinese and Persian porcelain found at the site show how far those connections reached. [2]

Recent scholarship has pushed attention in exactly this direction. Chirikure argues that accounts of Great Zimbabwe have centred too heavily on rulers and imported luxuries, and that the households and local production of ordinary people deserve a much larger place in explaining how the city worked. [4] That does not make the society equal or its rulers powerless. It changes where we look.

This book will try to look in both places: at the walls and at the hands, at the kings and at the households that fed them. A civilisation is not only its monuments. It is the arrangements that allow thousands of people to contribute to something none of them could build alone.

And Great Zimbabwe is only one page. Long before its walls rose, the Kingdom of Kush had built royal cities, temples and water works around Meroë in what is now Sudan. [19] Aksum, in the highlands of present-day Ethiopia and Eritrea, traded across the Red Sea and began minting its own coins in the third century. [20] On the coast of present-day Tanzania, the Swahili towns of Kilwa Kisiwani and Songo Mnara built houses and mosques of stone and coral and traded across the Indian Ocean. [21]

These places are separated by thousands of kilometres and many centuries. They cannot be pressed into a single African golden age. Each has its own chronology, its own achievements

and its own failures. The chapters that follow will take them one at a time.

A Past with Contradictions

Recovering achievement brings relief. Something dismissed becomes visible. Something declared impossible becomes undeniable. But relief can harden into defensiveness, until every difficult finding feels like an attack on belonging.

Consider the manuscripts of Timbuktu shown by the Library of Congress in 2003. Among them were a text on the laws of commerce composed in verse and a primer for teaching arithmetic. Beside them were a document concerning the sale and transport of enslaved people and a certificate granting freedom to an enslaved woman. [22]

Those documents belong together. A society can produce sophisticated scholarship and hold human beings as property in the same centuries and the same cities. Recognising the scholarship does not approve the slavery. Recognising the slavery does not deny the scholarship. Both are true, and an honest history has to carry both.

The same honesty applies when the subject becomes conquest. The existence of conflict and injustice inside African societies never justified invasion from outside. And invasion from outside does not make every African exercise of power innocent. Different people bear different responsibilities within the same history.

That is also why this book will be careful with two small words: “Africa” and “we”. A ruler who sold captives, a trader who carried them, the captive and the person who hid from the raiders were all African. They did not share the same interests, the same power or the same guilt. To write that “Africa chose” something would require us to say who chose, whom they could command and who resisted them. The continent is not a single character, and its history is not a single plot.

The past becomes useful when it is allowed to challenge us. If it only confirms what we already wish to believe, we should look again at how we selected it.

The Letters and Their Relationships

Place six letters on a page: A, F, R, I, C, A. We recognise the word because of their order and because we have learned to read it. Change the arrangement and the meaning changes, or disappears.

That is the image behind this trilogy. People are the letters: distinct, each with its own shape, its own sound and its own dignity. Institutions are the grammar: the rules and practices by which people exercise authority, make decisions, share responsibilities and settle disputes. Shared progress is the sentence: what people can build together that none of them could build alone.

The image has limits, and they matter as much as the image itself. People are not marks waiting for a powerful hand to place them. They can object, refuse, imagine alternatives and change the rules under which they cooperate. A person keeps their worth when an institution fails them, when their contribution is overlooked, or when they cannot contribute at all. No ruler, reformer or author is entitled to arrange human beings as passive letters in a sentence of his own choosing. And the word *Africa* itself teaches the most important lesson: it needs different letters. Six identical letters would spell nothing.

Imagine a group of neighbours who agree to maintain a shared well. Their goodwill is not enough. Who digs? Who decides what repair is needed? What happens to a family that cannot contribute, and how is that different from a family that will not? How can someone challenge an unfair demand? The well will be kept only if the neighbours find answers they can trust. That is grammar.

Grammar can also be bent toward bad sentences. People can organise efficiently around an abusive purpose. A system that

coordinates well is not, for that reason alone, a just one. So this book will ask two questions of every arrangement it examines: how did it work, and what did it require people to endure?

The title *Origins* might suggest a single morning on which the letters were scattered. There was no such morning. Every point at which we enter African history has something before it. Institutions kept old names while changing their purposes. Practices survived by adapting. Some arrangements were imposed from outside; others were made, or remade, by Africans themselves. The conflict was not created in a day. It accumulated.

The Question We Will Follow

The chapters ahead move through selected African worlds before turning to the forces that broke and reshaped them. Part One visits the Nile and the Horn, the Sahel, the stone and coastal cities of the south and east, the kingdoms of the forest, and the many ways African societies, including the kingdoms of the Great Lakes, organised power. Part Two follows the trades in human beings and the conquest that drew new borders across living worlds. Part Three asks what independence inherited, what Africans did with that inheritance, and how documented greatness came to sound, to many of its own descendants, like a fairy tale.

That route does not mean every African society passed through the same stages. Nor does it mean the present was inevitable. The people living through these histories could not see how their stories would end. Wherever the evidence allows, we will try to recover the choices that were open to them, so that we can tell the difference between a constraint we inherited and a habit we have chosen to keep.

There will be injuries for which responsibility must be named. There will be achievements that deserve to be known. There will be decisions whose consequences were mixed, contested or very different from what their makers intended. A general

accusation produces anger without direction. A precise explanation can show where authority sat, how an incentive worked and why a correction failed. Only the second can help us build anything.

The Letter Principle

A people can lose its history in two ways. Others can take the authorship of its achievements, as the travellers and officials took the walls of Great Zimbabwe. Or its own children can stop asking how those achievements were made, and keep only the pride or only the grievance. Both losses leave the letters without their grammar. To recover a history is not to choose the most comforting story. It is to recover the full sentence — the builders and the burdens, the brilliance and the injustice — so that we can understand what it once took to make meaning together, and what it would take to do it again.

Questions for Reflection

1. Before reading this chapter, had you heard of Great Zimbabwe, and who did you assume had built it? Where did that knowledge, or its absence, come from?
2. Karl Mauch saw the evidence and still told the wrong story. What assumptions might shape how you read the evidence about your own society today?
3. The Rhodesian guidebook did not deny the evidence; it insisted on “balance”. Where do you see false balance used to keep a settled question open?
4. Whose stories are missing from the history you were taught at school? Who in your family or community still carries them?
5. Can you admire an achievement while acknowledging the injustice inside the society that produced it? Choose an example from your own country’s past.

* * *

The walls are still standing in their valley. They were not waiting for a stranger to explain them, and they are not waiting for us to worship them. They are waiting, as all evidence waits, to be read honestly.

The next chapter turns north, to the Nile and the Horn, where queens of Kush made war on Rome and the kings of Aksum stamped their names in gold.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 2

Nile, Kush, and the Horn

> *“Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God.”*
>
> — Psalm 68:31 (King James Version)

In December 1910 a team led by the British archaeologist John Garstang was digging at Meroë, the old royal city of Kush on the east bank of the Nile in what is now Sudan. Beneath the staircase of a small temple, in a pocket of clean sand about two and a half metres below the surface, the workers uncovered a bronze head of heroic size. [23]

At first the excavators thought it showed the Roman prince Germanicus. Comparison with other portraits settled the question. It was Augustus, the first emperor of Rome, cast in bronze within a few years of 27 BCE, larger than life, and preserved for more than nineteen centuries by the dry heat of the Sudanese desert. It is now in the British Museum. [23]

A Roman emperor’s head had no obvious reason to be in Meroë, more than a thousand kilometres south of the nearest Roman garrison. And it had even less reason to be buried under a doorstep, in a temple whose walls were painted with bound prisoners, where everyone who climbed the stairs would walk over the face of the most powerful man in the Mediterranean world. [23]

The explanation lies in a war that Roman writers recorded and Kushite writers recorded in a language we still cannot fully read. To follow it, we have to set aside one of the oldest habits in the telling of African history: the habit of meeting Africa only when someone from elsewhere arrives.

This chapter asks a simple question about the Nile and the Horn of Africa. What did it take for societies here to build states that could negotiate with Rome, rule Egypt and trade across the Red Sea, and who carried the weight of that power?

A Queen Against Rome

The Greek geographer Strabo, a contemporary of these events, tells the story from the Roman side. In the mid-20s BCE, while part of the Roman army in Egypt was away on campaign in Arabia, an army from the south crossed the frontier at the First Cataract of the Nile. It took Syene, Elephantine and Philae. According to Strabo, the invaders "enslaved the inhabitants, and also pulled down the statues of Caesar." [24]

The Roman prefect Gaius Petronius struck back "with less than ten thousand infantry and eight hundred cavalry against thirty thousand men". He drove the southern army back, took the fortified towns of Pselchis and Premnis, and pushed upriver as far as Napata, an ancient royal centre of Kush, which he razed. [24]

Strabo calls the ruler of the southern kingdom Candace and describes her, through Roman eyes, as "a masculine sort of woman, and blind in one eye." [24] The name was in fact a title. *Kandake* was the word Kushites used for a royal woman of the highest rank, and inscriptions at Meroë and Naqa name a queen who carried both that title and the title *qore*, ruler: Amanirenas. Most historians identify her as Strabo's Candace. The identification rests on her titles and on inscriptions in the Meroitic language, which remains only partly understood, so it is a strong inference rather than a certainty. [25]

The war did not end with a Roman march on Meroë. Strabo records that the queen sent envoys to negotiate. Petronius passed them on to Augustus, who was then on the Greek island of Samos. The envoys obtained what they asked for, and the emperor "even remitted the tributes which he had imposed." [24] A frontier zone was agreed between the two powers, and the Kushite capital was never taken. [25]

The head beneath the steps belongs to the opening of that war. It is most likely one of the statues of Augustus pulled down in the raid on Roman Egypt, carried south as a trophy and buried at the threshold of a shrine to victory. [23]

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

In recent years the story of Amanirenas has travelled widely as the tale of "the one-eyed African queen who defeated Rome." The record is more interesting than the slogan.

Kush did not defeat Rome in battle. A Roman army penetrated deep into Kushite territory and destroyed Napata. What Kush achieved was something rarer and, for the people living along the Nile, more useful. It fought the most powerful empire of its age to a standstill, then negotiated a peace on better terms than Rome usually granted: no tribute, an agreed frontier and a capital left standing. [24][25]

That is a lesson in statecraft, not only in courage. A kingdom that can raise an army, sustain a war, send envoys across the Mediterranean and bargain with an emperor is a kingdom with institutions — treasuries, officials, messengers, records and a court able to decide what it wanted. The slogan remembers the queen. The evidence asks us to remember the state.

Older Than Rome

By the time Amanirenas faced Rome, Kush was already ancient. Its story is usually told as a footnote to Egypt's, as though the lands south of the First Cataract were a frontier province waiting to be civilised from the north. The evidence says otherwise.

Around 2500 BCE a state formed at Kerma, near the Third Cataract of the Nile. Its capital grew around a massive mud-brick temple known today as the Western Deffufa, whose base measures more than fifty metres by twenty-six. By about 1700 BCE the city had at least ten thousand inhabitants, and its cemetery holds more than thirty thousand graves. [26]

The American archaeologist George Reisner, who excavated Kerma early in the twentieth century, assumed it had been an Egyptian outpost and read its great temple as a fort. Decades of later excavation by the Swiss archaeologist Charles Bonnet showed instead a large, independent African city with its own architecture, burial customs and political power, trading with

Egypt rather than serving it. [26] It is the same pattern we met at Great Zimbabwe: a monument attributed to outsiders until the evidence was read on its own terms.

Egypt's New Kingdom eventually conquered Upper Nubia, and for several centuries the region was ruled from the north. [26] But Kush revived around Napata and the sacred mountain of Jebel Barkal, and in the eighth century BCE the direction of power reversed.

Around 728 BCE the Kushite king Piye marched north and defeated a coalition of rulers in the Nile Delta. He recorded the campaign on a great victory stela. His successors took the full titles of pharaoh, and Kushite kings ruled Egypt as its Twenty-fifth Dynasty until the 650s BCE. [27] One of them, Taharqa, who ruled from 690 to 664 BCE, appears in the Hebrew Bible as "Tirhakah king of Ethiopia" — the Hebrew text says Kush — marching out against the Assyrian king Sennacherib. [27][28] It was the Assyrians, in the end, who drove the Kushite pharaohs out of Egypt. [27]

So the relationship between Egypt and Kush was not that of a teacher and a pupil. At some times Egypt ruled Kush. At others Kush ruled Egypt. For most of three thousand years they traded, fought, married, worshipped and borrowed from each other. Both were African.

Meroë: Iron, Water and a Script We Cannot Yet Read

From the third century BCE onward, most Kushite royal burials took place at Meroë, further south, where the kingdom's heartland lay between the Nile and the Atbara. UNESCO describes the Kingdom of Kush as a major power from the eighth century BCE to the fourth century CE, and the remains around Meroë include pyramids, temples, palaces, industrial areas and installations for storing water. [19][29] Royal pyramids still stand in clusters on the ridges east of the city, steeper and smaller than those of Egypt, more numerous than most visitors expect.

Meroë was also a city of fire. Excavations have found furnaces and great mounds of slag, the glassy waste left by smelting iron. New radiocarbon dates suggest that iron was being produced there on a significant scale by the seventh or sixth century BCE, and that production continued for more than a thousand years. The archaeologists now working on the site describe Meroë as one of the largest ironmaking centres in Africa. [30] Iron meant tools for farmers, weapons for armies and goods for trade. It also meant fuel, labour and knowledge passed carefully from one generation of smelters to the next.

And Meroë wrote. From about the third century BCE the Kushites used a script of their own, in two forms: a monumental hieroglyphic form for temples and a cursive form for everyday use. Its twenty-three signs record the Meroitic language. In 1909 the British Egyptologist Francis Llewellyn Griffith worked out the sound values of the signs, using Egyptian names spelled in Meroitic. [31]

That was a remarkable achievement, and it left a strange result. We can now read Meroitic aloud. We can pronounce the names of its queens and gods and the words on their monuments. But the language itself remains poorly understood. [31] Most of its sentences are still closed to us.

There is no image in African history closer to the heart of this trilogy. The letters survive. We can sound every one of them. What we have lost is the grammar that once made them mean.

When UNESCO convened scholars in Cairo in 1974 for the *General History of Africa*, the second part of the meeting was devoted to the decipherment of Meroitic. Among its recommendations was that Sudanese students be trained in the languages of Sudan, so that the work of understanding could be carried on by the people closest to it. [32]

Kush was known far beyond its borders in its own time. The New Testament records the conversion of an official from this kingdom, “an eunuch of great authority under Candace queen of the Ethiopians, who had the charge of all her treasure.” [28] The writer used the same royal title Strabo had heard. A Kushite

treasurer returning from Jerusalem and reading the prophet Isaiah in his chariot tells us something no pyramid can: that this was a state with officials, finances, literacy and connections that reached across the known world.

Who Carried the Weight

It would be easy to stop there, with queens and pyramids, iron and treasure. But this book promised to look at the hands as well as the walls.

Kush's power was not gentle. Strabo's account opens with a Kushite army enslaving the inhabitants of the towns it captured. [24] The temple where the head of Augustus was buried was painted with bound prisoners beneath a ruler's feet. [23] Pyramids, temples and furnaces required the labour of many people who left no names, and the fuel for a thousand years of smelting had to come from somewhere. The surviving evidence tells us far more about the rulers who commanded that labour than about the people who performed it.

Nor was Kush only a victim of larger empires. It was itself a power that raided, conquered and ruled. In the fourth century CE, as Meroë declined, it in turn became the target of a rising kingdom in the highlands to the east.

An inscription of King Ezana of Aksum, from about the middle of the fourth century, describes a campaign against the Noba along the rivers of the Nile valley: villages burned, goods seized, enemies pursued for days. As transcribed by historians, it lists prisoners — 214 men and 415 women — alongside the dead and many thousands of captured cattle and sheep. [33] Behind each number was a person taken from a home.

These records do not cancel the achievements of Kush or Aksum. They complete them. States that could build and trade could also capture and enslave, and the same institutions that organised a treasury could organise a raid. An honest history keeps both in the same frame.

Aksum: A Kingdom Between Empires

Aksum rose in the highlands of what are now northern Ethiopia and Eritrea, and lasted, as a kingdom, from roughly the first to the eighth century CE. UNESCO calls it "the most powerful state between the Eastern Roman Empire and Persia." [34] Through its Red Sea port at Adulis it traded with Egypt, Arabia, the Mediterranean and India, and from the third century it minted its own coins in gold, silver and bronze. [20][35]

Its rulers marked their capital with stone stelae carved to resemble many-storeyed buildings, with false doors and windows cut into the granite. The largest still standing rises more than twenty-three metres. The largest of all, some thirty-three metres long, lies broken where it fell. [34]

Under Ezana, in the middle of the fourth century, the kingdom turned to Christianity, a change associated with a missionary named Frumentius. On Ezana's coins the old symbol of the sun and moon gives way to the cross. [35] His inscriptions were written in three languages — Greek for the wider world, the old South Arabian script and Ge'ez, the language of Aksum — and around this time Ge'ez writing began to mark vowels. [34][36]

Here the story of Aksum parts company with the story of Meroë. Ge'ez ceased to be spoken as an everyday language sometime between about 900 and 1200, but it never stopped being read. It continues today as a liturgical language. [37] And the script developed to write it is still used, in adapted form, for Amharic in Ethiopia and Tigrinya in Eritrea and Ethiopia. [36]

Meroë's letters can be sounded but not understood. Aksum's letters, in their modern forms, are read every day by millions of people writing Amharic and Tigrinya. The difference is not that one people was more intelligent than the other. It is that one set of letters was carried by an institution — a church, its schools, its scribes and its liturgy — that kept teaching them, generation after generation, through every change of dynasty. The other was not.

In 1937, during the Italian occupation of Ethiopia, one of the Aksum stelae was taken to Rome as a trophy. It stood there for

decades. Italy returned it in April 2005, and it was raised again at Aksum in 2008. [38] We will return in Chapter 10 to what it means when the monuments of a people are carried away, and what it means when they come home.

Egypt and the Question of Belonging

No discussion of the Nile can avoid the oldest argument of all: whether ancient Egypt belongs to African history.

Hegel answered no. In the same lectures in which he declared Africa "no historical part of the World", he divided the continent into parts and set the Nile valley apart from what he called Africa proper, treating Egypt as a bridge to Asia and Europe rather than an African achievement. [10] Generations of writers followed him, presenting Egypt as an honorary member of the Mediterranean or the Near East and leaving the rest of the continent without it.

The most forceful reply came from the Senegalese scholar Cheikh Anta Diop (1923–1986), whose *Nations nègres et culture* (1954) argued that ancient Egypt was a Black African civilisation whose language and culture were related to those of peoples further south and west. [39] Diop wrote the opening chapter on the origins of the ancient Egyptians for the second volume of UNESCO's *General History of Africa*, and in 1974 his thesis was debated at a symposium in Cairo. [32][39]

The published report of that meeting is a useful guide to what is settled and what is not. The scholars present broadly agreed that the population of the Nile valley had been stable since before the first dynasties, and the older picture of a uniformly light-skinned Egyptian population was quietly abandoned. They disagreed about whether the earliest population was homogeneously Black, as Diop and the Congolese scholar Théophile Obenga argued, or mixed, as others maintained, and about Diop's proposed links between ancient Egyptian and languages such as Wolof. One participant summarised a widely

shared view: the unity of the Egyptian people was cultural rather than racial. [32]

The debate has not ended. Many historians have criticised Diop's reliance on older racial categories and some of his linguistic methods, while others credit him with forcing scholarship to restore Egypt to African history. [39] In 2025 the committee responsible for the final volumes of the *General History of Africa* concluded that ancient Egypt had both African and Eurasian populations and identified Upper Egypt, in the south, as the origin of pharaonic unification. [40]

This book takes a position that does not depend on settling every detail of ancient skin colour. Egypt stands on African soil, drew on the Nile and the peoples of its southern valley, and was entwined with Kush for three thousand years. It belongs to African history. But it is not the only African civilisation, and African history does not need Egypt in order to be great. Kerma, Kush and Aksum did not borrow their importance from the pharaohs. They earned it.

The Letter Principle

Kush and Aksum built states that could raise armies, negotiate with emperors, mint coins, smelt iron and write in their own scripts. They also captured and enslaved. Both truths belong to the record. But their deepest lesson for this trilogy lies in what happened to their letters. A script survives as long as there are institutions that teach it, use it and hand it on. When the schools, the scribes and the courts that sustained Meroitic disappeared, its signs outlived their meaning. When a church kept teaching Ge'ez, its letters crossed fifteen centuries. Knowledge does not survive because it is carved in stone. It survives because people build arrangements that keep passing it on. A civilisation that does not organise its own continuity will one day have its words read aloud by strangers who cannot tell what they mean.

Questions for Reflection

1. Before reading this chapter, had you heard of Kush, Kerma or Aksum? Which did you know more about: these kingdoms, or ancient Rome?
2. The story of Amanirenas is often told as a victory over Rome. Why might a negotiated peace be a greater achievement than a battlefield victory?
3. Meroitic can be read aloud but not understood; Ge'ez is still read every week. What institutions in your own society keep knowledge alive across generations, and which are at risk?
4. Ezana's inscription counts prisoners alongside cattle. How should we hold admiration for ancient kingdoms together with the suffering their power caused?
5. Does it matter whether ancient Egypt is counted as African history? What changes for you if it is, and what remains true either way?

* * *

The head of Augustus no longer lies beneath the steps at Meroë. It sits behind glass in London, looking out at visitors who mostly do not know whose feet once passed over it.

The next chapter crosses the continent westward, to the Sahel, where gold moved north across the desert, scholars copied books in Timbuktu, and a king of Mali made a pilgrimage that people still talked about centuries later.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 3

Gold, Manuscripts, and the Cities of Knowledge

> *"They are seldom unjust, and have a greater abhorrence of injustice than any other people."*
>
> — Ibn Battuta, on the people of Mali, 1350s

In 1324 a king from the far west of Africa passed through Cairo on his way to Mecca. His name was Musa, and he ruled Mali, an empire that stretched across the grasslands south of the Sahara. He travelled with a great retinue, and he travelled with gold.

About twelve years later, a Damascus-born scholar and official named al-Umari set down what the people of Cairo remembered. He had asked an emir who had received the king, and the emir had told him of the sultan's opulence and piety. Musa, he wrote, "forwarded to the royal treasury many loads of unworked native gold and other valuables." He "left no court emir nor holder of a royal office without the gift of a load of gold." His people spent freely in the markets. "They exchanged gold until they depressed its value in Egypt and caused its price to fall," al-Umari recorded, adding: "This has been the state of affairs for about twelve years until this day." [41]

Half a century later, on a great map of the known world made on the Mediterranean island of Majorca, a cartographer painted a crowned African king seated on a throne. The caption reads: "This black Lord is called Musse Melly and is the sovereign of the land of the black people of Gineva." [42] Europe had begun to draw Africa's kings, and it drew this one holding gold.

The image has lasted. Mansa Musa is remembered today as the king so rich he crashed a currency. But gold does not dig itself up, carry itself across a desert or turn itself into books. Behind the pilgrimage stood something less dazzling and far more important: an arrangement of rulers, miners, merchants,

scholars, taxes, roads and laws that made the wealth possible and made it useful.

This chapter asks what that arrangement was. How did the societies of the Sahel turn gold and trade into states and scholarship, and who carried the cost?

Before Mali: The Kingdom Called Ghana

Mali was not the first great power of the western Sahel. Centuries earlier, Arabic writers described a kingdom they called Ghana.

Around 1068, in Córdoba in Muslim Spain, the geographer al-Bakri compiled an account of it from the reports of merchants and travellers. He never visited the region himself. "The City of Ghana consists of two towns situated on a plain," he wrote. One, "inhabited by Muslims, is large and possesses twelve mosques." The king's town, some miles away, was called al-Ghaba. Near the king's court of justice stood a mosque for Muslim visitors. [43]

Al-Bakri also recorded two rules that tell us how the kingdom worked. "The nuggets found in all the mines of his country are reserved for the king." And "on every donkey-load of salt when it is brought into the country their king levies one gold dinar." [43]

Those two sentences describe a state. The king controlled the largest pieces of the region's most valuable product and taxed the movement of its most needed import. Salt came south across the desert; gold went north. A kingdom that sat between them, kept the roads open and took its share could grow rich without owning either the salt pans or most of the gold fields. That is grammar: rules that turned trade into public revenue.

The capital itself remains a puzzle. For much of the twentieth century, archaeologists identified the ruins of Koumbi Saleh, in what is now south-eastern Mauritania, as the Muslim town al-Bakri described. More recent scholars have questioned the identification, and the king's town has never been found. [44] When the Gold Coast won its independence in 1957, it took the name of this ancient kingdom, even though medieval Ghana lay far to the north-west of the new nation's borders. [45] Like

Zimbabwe, a modern African state reached back for a name that colonial history had taught the world to forget.

The Word of the Griots

Mali's own account of its beginnings was not written in Arabic. It was spoken and sung.

Among the Mande peoples, hereditary specialists called *jeli* — often known in English by the French word *griots* — preserve genealogies, praise songs and the epic of Sunjata Keita, the founder of the empire. In the version most widely known outside West Africa, written down in French by the Guinean historian Djibril Tamsir Niane and published in 1960, Sunjata overcomes exile and disability, gathers allies and defeats the sorcerer-king Sumanguru at the battle of Krina, which tradition places in the 1230s. [46]

The epic is not a chronicle. It is a living work of memory, shaped by generations of tellers and by the families whose ancestors it honours. That makes it more valuable, not less. It tells us what the Mande remembered, what they believed a ruler owed his people, and which alliances they considered the foundations of their society. But it has to be read as what it is.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

In 2009 UNESCO inscribed the Manden Charter, proclaimed at Kurukan Fuga, on its list of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. UNESCO describes it as proclaimed in the early thirteenth century, after a major military victory, by the founder of the Mande empire and his assembly of wise men. Its provisions concern social peace in diversity, the inviolability of the human being, education, food security, the abolition of slavery by raiding, and freedom of expression and trade. Its words and rituals are still passed on orally, and ceremonies are held each year at Kangaba. [47]

On the internet, the charter has become something else: “the world’s first declaration of human rights,” often printed as a numbered list of forty-four articles and dated precisely to 1236.

That numbered text has a modern history. It was assembled at a regional workshop held in Kankan, Guinea, in 1998, where participants worked with oral traditions to “reconstruct” the charter, under the supervision of a member of the Kouyaté griot family. Niane himself described the reconstruction as a declaration on the rights of man. Historians have raised serious questions. The French historian Francis Simonis observed that no Malian griots were invited to the workshop and that the resulting text gives special prominence to the family that organised it. The Dutch anthropologist Jan Jansen has called it a recent invention rather than a credible historical document. [48]

None of this means the Mande had no ideas about rights, justice or limits on power. The tradition UNESCO recognised is real, and Ibn Battuta’s testimony, which we shall come to, suggests that Mali took justice seriously. What the evidence corrects is the form of the claim. The tradition is ancient; the article-by-article document is modern. To honour oral tradition is to understand how it works: as memory carried and reshaped by living people, not as a lost parchment waiting to be recovered word for word.

An African history that cannot tell the difference between the two will one day be embarrassed by its own enthusiasm. An African history that can tell the difference has nothing to fear from scrutiny.

A Kingdom Seen by a Stranger

In 1352 the Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta crossed the Sahara and spent months in Mali, during the reign of Musa’s brother Sulayman. He was a difficult guest. He complained about his reception and about customs that offended his sense of propriety. But he also left one of the most striking descriptions of any medieval state, written by a man with no reason to flatter it.

"They are seldom unjust, and have a greater abhorrence of injustice than any other people," he wrote. "There is complete security in their country. Neither traveller nor inhabitant in it has anything to fear from robbers or men of violence." And: "They do not confiscate the property of any white man who dies in their country, even if it be uncounted wealth." [49]

Read those sentences as a merchant would. A caravan crossing the Sahara risked everything: camels, goods, capital and life. It would make the journey only to places where roads were safe, contracts were honoured and the property of a foreigner who died far from home would reach his heirs. Security and the protection of property were not luxuries. They were the institutions on which the gold trade, and the empire, depended.

The same traveller recorded what else he saw. "The women servants, slave-girls, and young girls go about in front of everyone naked," he complained. [49] His objection was to their dress. What we notice is that slave-girls were an ordinary part of the society he was describing.

Timbuktu

Of all the cities of the Sahel, one became a byword. Timbuktu stood near the great bend of the Niger, where the river reaches furthest into the desert, and in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries it became an intellectual and spiritual capital of West Africa. [50]

Its three great mosques, Djingareyber, Sankore and Sidi Yahia, still stand. UNESCO credits the initial construction of Djingareyber to Kankan Moussa — Mansa Musa — on his return from the pilgrimage, and records that it was rebuilt and enlarged between 1570 and 1583 by the city's judge, Imam al-Aqib. The mosques are built of earth and kept standing by regular maintenance using traditional techniques. UNESCO's description of the city counts some 180 Qur'anic schools and 25,000 students in its golden age, when Sankore was a renowned centre of teaching. [50]

Earth architecture carries its own lesson. A stone wall can stand for centuries while the society that built it disappears. A mud mosque survives only if a community returns, season after season, to repair it. Timbuktu's mosques are monuments to continuous organisation.

The manuscripts tell the same story. The scholars of Timbuktu copied, studied and wrote works of law, theology, grammar, astronomy, medicine and commerce, and private families built libraries that they handed down for generations. The texts shown by the Library of Congress in 2003 included a treatise on the laws of commerce in verse and a primer of arithmetic. [22] Knowledge here was not a private gift. It was organised: taught, copied, stored, inherited and protected.

By the late fifteenth century, Timbuktu belonged to a new power. Sunni Ali, who ruled from about 1464 to 1492, built the empire of Songhai around the city of Gao and drove out the Tuareg, who had held Timbuktu since 1433. His successor Askia Muhammad, who ruled from 1493 to 1528, "welded the central region of the western Sudan into a single empire." At its height it reached from central Mali to the Atlantic and east into present-day Niger and Nigeria. [51] Its rulers had to balance the interests of pastoralist subjects who held to older religions and Muslim city dwellers on whose wealth and scholarship the empire depended. [51]

Who Carried the Weight

The cities of knowledge were also cities of bondage. The Timbuktu documents shown in 2003 included a contract concerning the sale and transport of enslaved people and a certificate freeing an enslaved woman. [22] Captives were among the goods that crossed the Sahara northward, alongside gold.

The most famous scholar of Timbuktu wrestled with this directly. Ahmad Baba (1556–1627), jurist and author of dozens of books, wrote a treatise on slavery known as *Mi'raj al-Su'ud*, *The*

Ladder of Ascent. In it he argued that free Muslims could not lawfully be enslaved and that buyers must establish a captive's religion before purchase. He rejected the idea that skin colour, or the supposed curse of Ham, could justify slavery. The only lawful ground, he held, was unbelief. [52]

That position deserves to be weighed carefully. Ahmad Baba confronted, centuries before the Atlantic abolitionists, the claim that Black people were destined for slavery, and refuted it. And in the same pages he accepted that non-Muslims could lawfully be enslaved. [52] The finest legal mind of the city reasoned against racial slavery and within religious slavery at once. Both facts belong to the history of Timbuktu, and neither cancels the other.

The Day the Scholars Were Taken

In 1591 an army sent by Ahmad al-Mansur, sultan of Morocco, crossed the Sahara. Using firearms, it defeated the Songhai army at Tondibi and went on to take Timbuktu and Gao. [51] The empire's economic and administrative centres stayed in Moroccan hands, and resistance failed to restore Songhai. [51]

In 1594 the occupiers accused Timbuktu's judge and other leading figures of subversion and deported them across the desert to Marrakesh. Ahmad Baba was among them. [52][53] In exile he taught and issued legal opinions admired for their clarity. He was allowed to go home only after the sultan's death in 1603, and did not reach Timbuktu until years later. [52][53]

We will examine conquest in Part Two. But note what this conquest took. Gold had made Songhai rich; it could not protect the scholars. An army with firearms carried off the minds that had made Timbuktu what it was. A city of knowledge can be emptied faster than it can be built.

The Librarians of Timbuktu

The manuscripts outlived the Moroccan conquest, colonial rule and independence. In 2012 they faced another war.

In March 2012, after a military coup in Bamako, armed Islamist groups took control of northern Mali, including Timbuktu. [54] They destroyed nine of the city's mausoleums of saints and the door of a mosque. In 2016 the International Criminal Court sentenced Ahmad al-Faqi al-Mahdi, who had led the destruction, to nine years in prison — the first person the court had ever convicted of destroying cultural heritage as a war crime. [55]

When the occupiers fled in January 2013, they set fire to manuscripts at the Ahmed Baba Institute, the public research library named after the scholar of the previous section. The city's mayor told a British newspaper: "They have burned the manuscripts." [56] The world mourned the loss of Timbuktu's libraries.

The loss was real. UNESCO later counted 4,203 manuscripts burned or stolen out of the institute's 46,000. [54] But most of the city's manuscripts had already gone.

Beginning in May 2012, Abdel Kader Haidara, a librarian whose family had kept manuscripts for generations, organised a quiet evacuation. Before dawn, staff wrapped the manuscripts and packed them into metal lockers. Couriers carried the lockers at night to the homes of Timbuktu families. By July, around 1,700 lockers were hidden across the city. From October they were moved south toward Bamako by pushcart, donkey cart, bus and truck; when fighting closed the roads in January 2013, they went down the Niger by boat. Haidara estimated that around 95 per cent of the city's 300,000 manuscripts reached safety. "If you lose a manuscript," he said, "it's gone forever." [56]

In 1594 the scholars of Timbuktu were carried off and their city could not stop it. In 2012 the descendants of its manuscript-keeping families carried the books out themselves. What saved them was not a government or an army. It was an old institution — families who had treated the keeping of knowledge as a duty passed from parent to child — combined with courage, organisation and trust among people who knew one another.

The Letter Principle

Gold is a letter. On its own it means nothing; flooded into a market, it can even destroy its own value, as Cairo learned in 1324. What gave the gold of the Sahel its meaning was the grammar around it: rulers who taxed trade instead of seizing it, roads where travellers had nothing to fear, laws that protected a dead stranger's property, scholars who turned wealth into books, and families who kept those books for centuries. The same grammar had its cruelties, and the trade that carried gold also carried captives. But the lesson of the Sahel is clear. Wealth does not make a civilisation. Arrangements that make people safe, keep knowledge moving and outlast any single king do.

Questions for Reflection

1. Mansa Musa is remembered mostly for his wealth. What does this chapter suggest was more important to Mali's power than gold itself?
2. Ibn Battuta praised Mali's security and justice. Which institutions in your country make a stranger, a trader or an investor feel safe, and which make them afraid?
3. The Manden Charter is a real tradition, but its forty-four-article version is modern. Why does it matter to distinguish the two, and what is lost if we do not?
4. Ahmad Baba argued against racial slavery while accepting religious slavery. How should we judge thinkers who were ahead of their time in one way and of their time in another?
5. The manuscripts of Timbuktu were saved in 2012 by families, not by the state. What knowledge does your family or community keep, and how is it being handed on?

* * *

The gold that Musa carried to Cairo has long since been melted into other people's coins. The books his city gathered are still being read.

The next chapter turns south and east, to the stone city of Great Zimbabwe, the merchants of the Swahili coast and the bronze-casters of Ife and Benin, to ask how people who never met one another built such different forms of meaning.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 4

Stone, Sea, and Bronze

> *"These issues evidently so beclouded the minds of scholars that for a long time, indeed until the late 20th century, they denied the art of Africa a proper place in the history of universal human creative endeavor."*
>
> — Ekpo Eyo, Nigerian archaeologist

On the last day of 1932, a man named Mowena led a small party of white prospectors to a sandstone hill near the place where the Limpopo and Shashe rivers meet, on the border of what are now South Africa, Botswana and Zimbabwe. The farmer E. S. J. van Graan, his son and three companions climbed it. On the summit they found stone walls, and in the soil they found gold, iron, pottery and glass beads. [57]

Mowena knew the hill already. The local name for it was Mapungubwe, usually translated "hill of the jackal". The prospectors had come with a guide; history would remember them as the discoverers. [57]

Van Graan's son recognised what they had found and reported it to the head of the history department at the University of Pretoria. Within months the government bought the farm, the university took ownership of the gold, and excavation began. [57] Among the burials on the hilltop the excavators found objects of gold: a foil bowl, a sceptre, and a small rhinoceros that has since become one of the most famous objects in South Africa. [59]

For decades, few South Africans learned what the hill meant. South African History Online notes that after the first wave of publicity the university's excavations and findings were kept fairly secret and only made public after 1994. [57] The historian and curator Sian Tiley-Nel, who has spent much of her career with the Mapungubwe archive, writes that its prehistory was excluded during apartheid to support Eurocentric views of the

country's past, and that some scholars attributed the site to "non-Africans". [58] The collection was made properly accessible to the public only after 1999. [58] For two generations, a gold rhinoceros lay in a university collection while the country was taught a history that began with European ships.

Chapter 1 followed one such argument to Great Zimbabwe. This chapter is less interested in who denied the builders than in what the builders built. Between the eleventh and the fifteenth centuries, people in the Limpopo valley, on the coast of East Africa and in the forests of what is now southern Nigeria organised themselves in strikingly different ways: around a sacred hill, around a harbour, around a guild of metal-casters. How did each arrangement turn stone, sea or bronze into shared meaning, and who carried its cost?

The Hill of the Jackal

Mapungubwe did not begin on the hill. Around the year 1000, a farming community established a capital at the foot of a neighbouring rise, at a site archaeologists call K2. Its people kept cattle, grew millet and sorghum, worked iron, and traded down the Limpopo towards the Indian Ocean: gold, ivory and hides went out; glass beads, cloth and cowrie shells came in. [59]

Then, around 1220, the arrangement changed. The ruler and his close family moved to the summit of Mapungubwe Hill, a kidney-shaped block of sandstone ringed by cliffs, with their court officials around them. The commoners stayed below. The archaeologist Thomas Huffman describes this as the moment a community ranked by kinship became a society divided by class. In his words, "Mapungubwe's architecture and spatial arrangement provide the earliest evidence for class distinction and sacred leadership in southern Africa." [59]

"Sacred leadership" meant that the ruler's authority rested on a relationship with the land, the ancestors and God, made visible in rainmaking. The hill had been a rainmaking place before any king lived on it; the ruler moved into an existing source of sacred

power and became its keeper. [59] Height, stone and seclusion did the work that a constitution does elsewhere. They told every person in the valley where authority sat.

Mapungubwe had no gold of its own. The nearest goldfields lay in what are now Botswana and south-western Zimbabwe; copper came from the Musina area and iron from further north. The metal reached the hill through exchange, and the evidence for working bronze and gold is concentrated on the summit, where the rulers could control it. [59] Power lay less in owning a resource than in standing at the junction where resources met.

The hill's rulers were not the only people involved. The archaeologist Tim Forssman and his team have excavated Little Muck Shelter, a painted rock shelter four kilometres south of the Limpopo, and found that hunter-gatherers were still living in the area while the kingdom rose. They made bone tools and traded with farmers, and they obtained the glass beads and metal that marked wealth in the new society. "We cannot think about Mapungubwe's history without including hunter-gatherer societies," Forssman writes. [60] Even the most hierarchical arrangement in the valley had more letters in it than the royal graves suggest.

By about 1290 the hill was abandoned. Huffman connects the end to a drier climate that undermined leaders whose legitimacy depended on rain; others point to a shift in the gold trade towards routes that bypassed the Limpopo. [59] The two explanations are not exclusive. What is clear is where the pattern went next: north, to the granite hills of the Zimbabwe plateau, where the rulers of Great Zimbabwe built on the same model of a sacred elite set apart in stone. [59]

From the Plateau to the Sea

Great Zimbabwe's walls have already had a chapter. Its economy belongs here. The archaeologist Shadreck Chirikure has argued that the households and local production of ordinary people explain the city at least as much as its rulers' imported luxuries

do. [4] Those luxuries still tell us where the region's gold went: Chinese and Persian porcelain and coins from Kilwa have been found at the site. [2]

The gold left the plateau by way of the coast. Sofala, on the shore of present-day Mozambique, was the principal outlet for the gold and ivory of the interior. By the late twelfth century, according to the chronicle tradition of the town, the rulers of Kilwa, an island far to the north off the coast of present-day Tanzania, had taken control of Sofala. [62] A stone city on the plateau and a stone city on the sea were joined by the same commodity, and neither could have prospered in the same way without the other.

In about 1331 the Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta, whom we met in Mali in Chapter 3, sailed down the coast from Mogadishu to Kilwa. [63] A merchant told him that Sofala lay a fortnight's journey south "and that gold dust is brought to Sufala from Yufi in the country of the Limis, which is a month's journey distant from it." [61] He was describing, at second hand, the chain that ran from the goldfields of the interior to the harbour where he stood.

His description of the town is brief. "Kulwa is a very fine and substantially built town, and all its buildings are of wood," runs the standard English translation. [61] Archaeology adds what a visitor might have missed. Stone building at Kilwa began around the thirteenth century; before that, every house was of wattle and daub, and archaeologists read a household's standing from the kind of house it lived in. [63] The ruins of Kilwa Kisiwani and nearby Songo Mnara, with their houses and mosques of stone and coral, are now a World Heritage site. [21]

The sultan at the time of his visit, Ibn Battuta wrote, was "noted for his gifts and generosity"; he had seen him give the clothes off his back to a beggar. [61] This ruler is generally identified with al-Hasan ibn Sulaiman, who enlarged the Great Mosque of Kilwa and built the palace of Husuni Kubwa on a bluff above the sea: a building of coral stone with a court used for commerce, more than a hundred rooms and a stairway down to a mosque on the beach. [63] It was a palace and a warehouse at

once. Kilwa's rulers did not separate government from trade, because trade was what they governed.

Kilwa was not an empire in the inland sense. At its height in the fifteenth century, its sultans claimed authority over towns from the Mozambique coast to the islands of Zanzibar and Pemba, but the sultanate worked more like a confederation of commercial cities, each with its own elite and merchant communities, than a centralised state. [62] The grammar of the coast was partnership and rivalry among towns that needed one another's harbours.

A Coast of Many Ancestors

The Swahili towns kept their own account of where they came from. Kilwa's chronicle tells of Ali ibn al-Hassan, a son of a ruler of Shiraz in Persia, who sailed to the coast and bought the island from its African ruler. [62] A view widespread in colonial times went further and held that Africans had contributed little to the towns at all — the Great Zimbabwe pattern again, this time with the sea for an alibi. Later, some scholars answered by minimising outside contributions altogether.

In 2023 the largest study of ancient African DNA yet published tested the question directly, using the remains of 80 people from the Swahili coast and its inland neighbours, dating from about 1300 to 1900. It found that from around the year 1000, migrants from south-west Asia, mainly Persian men, married into coastal African communities and contributed close to half the ancestry of the people studied. It also found that the hallmarks of Swahili civilisation predated their arrival. [65] The study's co-senior author, the anthropologist Chapurukha Kusimba, put it plainly: "Archaeological evidence overwhelmingly showed that the medieval Swahili civilization was an African one." [65]

The detail is more interesting than either old answer. The newcomers were mostly men, with a smaller contribution from Indian women; the women they married were overwhelmingly African. The children of Persian fathers grew up speaking their

mothers' language and living in their mothers' kinship systems; the primary language, tomb architecture, cuisine and matrilocal marriage of the coast remained African and Bantu in character. The geneticist David Reich suggests that the newcomers "allied with and married into local trading families and adopted local customs to enable them to be more successful traders." [65] The findings, the researchers note, align with the oldest Swahili oral traditions of Shirazi arrivals. [65] The oral tradition was not wrong. It was incomplete in a way the colonial reading made worse.

The language tells the same story. Swahili is a Bantu language of the Sabaki branch, closely related to the languages of the Mijikenda and others on the coast. Perhaps 40 per cent of its vocabulary comes from Arabic, including its name, from an Arabic word meaning "of the coasts"; its grammar remains Bantu. The earliest known documents written in Swahili are letters sent from Kilwa in 1711, in Arabic script. [64] A borrowed word can enter a language without changing its grammar. That is a fair summary of the medieval coast.

The Heads of Ife

On the other side of the continent, in the forest country of the Yoruba, lies the city of Ife, which the Yoruba regard as a sacred city founded by the gods and the birthplace of humanity. Between about the twelfth and fifteenth centuries its artists made heads of terracotta and copper alloy of extraordinary naturalism. [66]

In 1910 the German ethnologist Leo Frobenius spent about three weeks in Ife. He was taken to a sacred grove where a copper-alloy head lay ritually buried, associated with Olokun, the god of the sea. He called it "a head of marvelous beauty, wonderfully cast in antique bronze, true to life, encrusted with a patina of glorious dark green." He pressed the priest of the grove to sell it, reportedly for six pounds. Ife's elders protested, the British colonial administration intervened, and Frobenius was

made to return the head, though he took several terracottas to Germany. [66]

He could not accept that Africans had made it. He proposed instead that survivors of the lost Atlantis had carried Greek civilisation to West Africa, and that Olokun was the Greek sea god Poseidon. The head, he wrote, showed "a symmetry, a vitality, reminiscent of Greece and a proof that, once upon a time, a race, far superior in strain to the Negro, had been settled here." [66] Mauch had found the Queen of Sheba in a Zimbabwean valley. Frobenius found Atlantis in a Yoruba grove. The method was the same: admire the work, then remove the authors.

The evidence came out of the ground. In 1938 more than a dozen copper-alloy heads were found in Ife, and by 1948 archaeologists accepted that they were the work of Yoruba artists. [66] Study has shown that the heads represent not gods but rulers, the *ooni* of Ife. In Yoruba thought, the head is the seat of *ori*, a person's inner self and destiny. [66] To make a ruler's head was to make an image of the place where his fate resided.

When the heads were exhibited at the British Museum in 1948, a London publication declared: "This African art is worthy to rank with the finest works of Italy and Greece." [66] It was meant as the highest praise. It also shows how far the measure still lay outside Africa. The Nigerian archaeologist Ekpo Eyo later wrote that scholars had for a long time "denied the art of Africa a proper place in the history of universal human creative endeavor." [66] The heads of Ife did not need to rank with Greece. They needed to be seen as what they were.

The Guild and the King

South-east of Ife lay the kingdom of Benin, ruled by the Edo people and their king, the *oba*, whose art would become even better known.

Benin remembers Ewuare, who took the throne around 1440 after a violent struggle with his brother that destroyed much of the city, as the king who remade it. According to the traditions

recorded by later historians, he rebuilt the capital, expanded the kingdom, reduced the power of the hereditary chiefs called the *uzama*, who had chosen earlier kings, and established succession by the eldest son. He also created new orders of town and palace chiefs appointed by and accountable to the oba. [67] The office of king grew stronger by taking powers that had belonged to others.

The bronze-casters were part of this arrangement. In Benin they formed a hereditary guild, the Igun-Eronmwon, whose members claim descent from a small number of founding families and who cast for the oba, his chiefs and priests. The kings granted them the exclusive right to the craft in return for serving the palace. In the early sixteenth century Oba Esigie gave them their own quarter and confirmed their monopoly, and casting flourished into the great series of brass plaques that recorded court life. [68] The guild still works on Igun Street in Benin City. [68]

A guild is grammar of a particular kind. It protects knowledge by restricting who may hold it, passes skill from parent to child, and ties a craft to a patron. The arrangement produced some of the finest metalwork in the world. It also meant that the art belonged, in a real sense, to the king.

From the late 1480s Benin had a new trading partner. The Portuguese kept a post at the port of Ughoton for some thirty years from 1487. The oba controlled the kingdom’s trade with outsiders and personally owned most of its high-value goods, among them ivory, pepper, coral and leopard skins. In 1514 the oba sent an embassy to the Portuguese court, apparently hoping to obtain firearms. [69] Benin dealt with Europe as a state that set terms, not as a coast waiting to be found. What happened to the kingdom in 1897 belongs to Chapter 10.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

Benin is also the subject of one of the most widely shared claims about African history: that the walls of Benin were four times longer than the Great Wall of China.

The figure comes from serious work. In the late 1960s and early 1970s the archaeologist Patrick Darling, then a teacher in Nigeria, began surveying the banks and ditches — in Edo, *iya* — that run through the forest around Benin City. He used an orienteering compass and paced the distances himself. Earlier mapping by the archaeologist Graham Connah had found about one kilometre of earthwork for every square kilometre of land. Applying that density to the 6,500 square kilometres over which the earthworks extended, Darling estimated their total length at about 10,000 miles, some 16,000 kilometres. In his own account, that made them "the world's longest ancient earthworks, some four or five times longer than the main Great Wall of China." [70] The *Guinness Book of Records* adopted the claim; its current entry still credits the earthworks of Benin and Ishan with an estimated 16,000 kilometres and some 150 million cubic metres of earth moved. [71]

So the number is real. But it is an estimate, extrapolated from density over an area, and it describes something different from what the slogan implies. The earthworks were not one wall built by one king. Connah's mapping, as Darling describes it, showed a composite of many separate settlements divided by wide bands of no-man's-land, progressively enclosed and fused over the centuries. Benin's court history remembered concentric city walls, the innermost dug by Oba Oguola and deepened by Ewuare. Darling concluded that the tradition of three concentric walls was no longer credible, and that the evidence pointed to a pattern of rural enclosure that predated the Benin dynasty, though he cautioned that no simple interpretation was secure. [70] Guinness's own summary notes that they may first have been dug to keep elephants out of farmland, and that they came to serve as agricultural and social boundaries. [71] NASA,

describing satellite images of their remains in 2025, calls them a "vast, cellular network" built in sections over hundreds of years. [72]

The comparison with China is also slippery. Darling compared the earthworks with the "main" Great Wall. In 2012 China's State Administration of Cultural Heritage completed a five-year survey that measured the whole system of Great Wall fortifications, including branches and spurs, at 21,196 kilometres. [73] Measured against that, the earthworks of Benin are shorter. Measured against the main wall, they are longer. The answer depends on what is being counted, and the two structures were built for different purposes.

None of this diminishes Benin. It changes the achievement. The slogan imagines a king commanding a single wall. The evidence describes thousands of farming communities, over many generations, digging boundaries that ordered land, marriage and protection, until their combined labour formed the largest earthworks made before machines. That is not a smaller story. It is a story about letters as well as kings.

Who Carried the Weight

Each of these arrangements was built on unequal burdens.

At Mapungubwe, preparing the hilltop for the rulers required the mobilisation of a large workforce, and the royal court controlled the cattle and the precious metals. Refuse from the commoners' settlement shows that rich and poor ate very different food. [59] The class division Huffman describes as a milestone in political complexity was, for those at the bottom of the hill, a division.

At Kilwa, the generosity Ibn Battuta admired had a source. "Its inhabitants are constantly engaged in military expeditions," he wrote, "for their country is contiguous to the heathen Zanj," and the sultan devoted a fifth of "the booty made on his expeditions" to pious and charitable purposes. [61] Charity at home was funded in part by raids on neighbours whom the town called

unbelievers. Nor was generosity guaranteed. The sultan's brother and successor, Ibn Battuta reported, told petitioners: "He who gave is dead, and left nothing behind him to be given." [61]

At Benin, the oba's control of trade included control over the sale of people. According to one modern account, he prohibited the sale of male slaves after 1516 because he needed men for his own army. [69] The restriction was a measure of the kingdom's strength, not a rejection of slavery. And the brass from which the famous bronzes were cast came, in large part, from the Atlantic trade. In 2023 a team led by Tobias Skowronek compared the chemistry of the Benin works with brass rings called manillas, used as currency in the European trade with West Africa, and identified the German Rhineland as the principal source of the manillas used in that trade between the fifteenth and eighteenth centuries. [74] Among the manillas they analysed were 768 recovered from the wreck of the *Whydah Gally*, a ship whose trade goods were destined for the West African slave trade. [74] The metal of Benin's court art passed through the same commerce that, in time, would carry millions of Africans across the ocean. Chapter 6 follows that commerce.

The Letter Principle

There is no single ladder of civilisation, with Greece at the top and everyone else climbing towards it. At Mapungubwe, people arranged themselves around a sacred hill and a ruler set apart in stone. At Kilwa, they arranged themselves around a harbour, and grandmothers kept a Bantu language alive in the homes of Persian merchants. In Ife and Benin, they arranged skill into guilds and authority into kingship, and made faces in metal that still stop strangers in museum galleries. Each arrangement produced its own meaning, and each placed its burdens on particular people. Different letters, different grammars, different sentences. The mistake of Mauch and Frobenius was to believe that only one sentence counted as writing. The opposite mistake is to read every sentence as a hymn.

Questions for Reflection

1. Mowena guided the prospectors to Mapungubwe, but history remembered them as its discoverers. Whose knowledge in your community is used without being credited?
2. At Mapungubwe, authority was expressed by height and seclusion; at Kilwa, by a palace that was also a warehouse. What do the buildings of power in your country say about the relationship between rulers and people?
3. The 2023 DNA study found that the children of Persian fathers spoke their African mothers' language. What does this suggest about who really carries a culture from one generation to the next?
4. Frobenius admired the Ife heads but denied their makers. Where do you see admiration for African work combined with doubt about African authorship today?
5. The Benin earthworks are often presented as one king's wall, but the evidence points to many communities over many centuries. Which achievements in your own society are credited to one leader that were really built by many people?

* * *

A gold rhinoceros, a coral palace, a bronze head and a ditch in the forest: none of them was made by a single person, and none of them explains itself. Each is the trace of an arrangement among people who decided, under pressure and with unequal power, how to live and work together.

The next chapter asks how those arrangements of power were built: in kingdoms such as Buganda, Bunyoro and Asante, and in societies that deliberately refused to have kings at all.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 5

The Grammar of African Power

> *"The Kabaka cannot see the face of his friend until he has eaten and is satisfied."*
>
> — Kauta, steward of Kabaka Mutesa I, to Henry Morton Stanley, April 1875

On 5 April 1875, Henry Morton Stanley's boat rounded an island on the northern shore of Lake Victoria and came in sight of Usavara, the hunting village of Mutesa I, Kabaka of Buganda. Five canoes escorted him. On a rise above the beach, thousands of people had arranged themselves in two dense lines. Muskets fired in salute, drums sounded, and flags were waved. At the head of the lines stood a short young man in a crimson robe over white cotton, before whom Stanley's escort knelt. This, Stanley was told, was the *Katekiro*. [11]

Stanley did not know what a *Katikkiro* was, so he bowed. The young man bowed back, "far more profound and stately" than Stanley had managed. Later, through a man from Zanzibar who served at the court, he learned that the *Katikkiro* was the prime minister, the Kabaka's deputy, and he wrote down the titles of the other chiefs who had come to meet him. [11]

Then the chiefs questioned him. They asked about his health and his journey, about Zanzibar and Europe, about the sun, moon and stars, about angels, devils, doctors, priests and craftsmen. "In one hour and ten minutes," Stanley recorded, "it was declared unanimously that I had 'passed.'" Only then did the Kabaka's steward, Kauta, arrive with fourteen oxen, sixteen goats and sheep and a hundred bunches of bananas, and a message: "The *Kabaka* cannot see the face of his friend until he has eaten and is satisfied." [11]

The man whose book would fix the phrase "the Dark Continent" in the public mind had been examined, assessed and admitted according to the protocol of an African state. Chapter 1

noted the irony of his visit. This chapter is about what he walked into: a grammar of power — titles, offices, councils, rituals and rules of access — that had been built over centuries and that ran without him.

Buganda was one way of arranging authority. It was not the only one. Some African societies concentrated power in a king and his appointees; others spread it among councils, clans and age-sets, and some refused kings altogether. How did these societies distribute authority, land and accountability, and what did each arrangement ask of the people inside it?

The Kabaka's Men

Buganda's own traditions place its origins in a small kingdom north of Lake Victoria, in what is now Busiro. By the nineteenth century it had grown into a large and formidable kingdom. [75] Two structures held it together, and they pulled in different directions.

The first was the clan. Every Muganda belonged, and belongs, to a clan (*ekika*), usually the father's, each identified by a totem animal or plant and each organised from the clan head downwards through branches and lineages. Members of a clan count themselves as kin and may not marry one another. The clans had seats on their own ancestral land and duties at the royal palace, and the Kabaka himself bears the title *Ssaabataka*, head of all the clan heads. [76] The clan gave every person a place, a history and an obligation that did not depend on the king's favour.

The second was the king's own administration. Alongside the hereditary clan heads (*bataka*), the Kabaka appointed chiefs of his own. The *bakungu* governed territories directly under him; the *batongole* acted as his representatives, "maintaining internal security, supervising royal estates and military duties." [75] In the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries the kings turned chiefly positions that had been inherited into positions they appointed, and as clans became social rather than residential groupings, the

clan heads lost much of their political power. By the nineteenth century Buganda was close to an absolute monarchy. [75]

Stanley saw this system mobilised for war. When he asked Mutesa for a muster-roll, the Kabaka summoned his principal chiefs and had them count their sub-chiefs. Stanley printed the list: the *Katikkiro*, who was also chief of Uddu (Buddu), came first, followed by the chiefs of the other provinces and of the royal household. Twelfth on the list, with ten sub-chiefs of her own, was "Nana Masurie, Mtesa's mother." [11]

She was not an exception. In Buganda three people could be called king, and two of them were women: the queen mother (*Namasole*) and the queen sister (*Lubuga*). The *Namasole* held her own courts and estates and collected taxes; the *Lubuga* had estates in every district and chiefs with the same titles as the king's. [75] Buganda was patriarchal. It was also a kingdom in which royal women governed.

The kingdom also kept its own history. Apolo Kagwa had been a page at the royal court when the first missionaries arrived, became one of the earliest Protestant converts, and survived the killings of Christians under Mutesa's son Mwanga. He served as *Katikkiro* from 1890 to 1926 and wrote, in Luganda, a history of the kings of Buganda, *Basekabaka be Buganda*, a treatise on Ganda law and custom and a collection of folklore. [77] At the same moment that European writers were declaring Africa without history, a Muganda prime minister was writing his kingdom's history in his own language. His position at the centre of the new colonial order shaped what he chose to record, as every historian's position does. [77]

The Older Kingdom

To Buganda's west and north lay Bunyoro-Kitara, for much of the period from the sixteenth to the nineteenth century one of the most powerful kingdoms in the region. Its rulers, the *Omukama*, belonged to the Babiito dynasty, which according to its own traditions succeeded the Bachwezi of the older Kitara. [78]

The two kingdoms remembered their relationship differently. Banyoro and Batooro traditions say that the first Babiito king sent his twin brother to rule the south-east, and that the brother declared independence and founded Buganda. Another tradition holds that a Babiito prince from Bunyoro founded Buganda's ruling line. Ganda tradition fiercely disputes both. [78] Here is the third witness of Chapter 1, the voice, speaking in two accents at once. Each tradition carries a claim about seniority and legitimacy. Neither can simply be read off as fact, and neither can be dismissed.

Bunyoro's great nineteenth-century king, Kabalega, and his long resistance to British conquest belong to Chapter 7.

The Stool and the King

On the other side of the continent, the Asante of the West African forest built a different answer to the problem of power.

In the late seventeenth century, the Asante states were subject to the kingdom of Denkyira. Their king, Osei Tutu, and his adviser, the priest Okomfo Anokye, built a union of Asante states around a single symbol: the Golden Stool. In 1701 the union defeated Denkyira at the battle of Feyiase, and its rulers recognised Kumasi as their centre and Osei Tutu as the *Asantehene*. [81]

According to tradition, Okomfo Anokye caused the stool to descend from the sky onto Osei Tutu's lap. It is believed to house the spirit of the Asante nation, living, dead and yet to be born. It must never touch the ground. At his enthronement, a new king is lowered and raised over the stool without sitting on it. [80] The king sits near the stool; he does not sit on it. The nation's soul is placed physically above any single holder of the office.

The arrangement had practical teeth. The Asantehene held great power, including the sole right to impose the death penalty, but shared legislative and executive power with councils and a bureaucracy in Kumasi that, by the nineteenth century, included a small foreign office with departments for dealing with the

British, French, Dutch and Arabs. Every chief swore fealty to the one above him, and the Asantehene in turn swore fealty to the state. A king who acted against the counsel of the elders or the people could be removed and reduced to a commoner. [81]

Kings come and go; the stool remains. The office is larger than the officer. It is as clear a statement of that principle as any political tradition has produced, and it was made in Africa.

Without Kings

Across the Niger from Benin, many Igbo communities chose another arrangement entirely. A popular saying holds that *Igbo enwe eze*: "the Igbo have no kings." [82] Most communities were governed by councils of elders and consultative assemblies, alongside lineage heads, age grades with public duties and title societies such as the Ozo, whose members were respected for their accomplishments but were not revered as kings. [82][83]

The Nigerian philosopher Kizito Okoli, writing in 2020, cautions against taking the saying literally. Kingship existed in some Igbo towns: Onitsha had kings called *Obi*, and Nri and Arochukwu had priest-kings. [83] Okoli argues that the slogan grew partly from a colonial misconception, born of the British failure to find a centralised king through whom to rule. But he also finds that "the Igbo are democratic and communalistic and manage their affairs through their traditional institutions led by elders; they never subscribe to one-man-for-all." [82]

This was not the absence of government. It was a deliberate refusal to concentrate it. When British administrators arrived in the early twentieth century, they wanted chiefs through whom to rule, and where they could not find them, they appointed "warrant chiefs" as though they were indigenous rulers. [83] The consequences of that decision belong to Chapter 7.

Anthropologists had a name for such societies. In 1940 Meyer Fortes and E. E. Evans-Pritchard published *African Political Systems*, the first attempt to compare African political organisation on what they called a "broad, comparative basis."

They noted that “many dogmatic opinions are held on the subject of African political organization and are even made use of in administrative practice.” [84] The book distinguished societies with centralised authority from those without it. Its categories were too tidy, and its readers included colonial administrators. But its basic finding stands: there was no single African way of governing.

Land, People and Flies

Why did some societies build kingdoms while others did not? Two strands of recent scholarship point to the land itself.

The political scientist Jeffrey Herbst argued in *States and Power in Africa* (2000) that across much of precolonial Africa, land was abundant and people were scarce. As the economist James Robinson summarised the argument, states therefore “did not fight over land, but rather people.” Borders were vague, and without the need to defend a well-defined territory, rulers had less reason to build the bureaucracies, censuses, tax collectors and standing armies that European states built. Robinson also drew out the darker implication: this helps explain why property rights in people — slavery — were well defined while rights in land were not. [85] Robinson himself accepted Herbst’s focus on the deep roots of state weakness but argued that the expansion of Europe from the fifteenth century, not population density, played the major role. [85] Strong states such as Buganda and Asante also sit awkwardly with any account of uniformly weak precolonial states.

The economist Marcella Alsan tested one ecological factor directly. The tsetse fly, found only in Africa, carries a parasite lethal to cattle and harmful to people. In a 2015 study she found that ethnic groups living in areas suited to the fly were less likely to use draught animals and the plough, had lower population densities and were less likely to be politically centralised; the same pattern does not appear in tropical regions outside Africa, where the fly does not exist. [86] Where animals could not

plough and carry, it was harder to produce the surplus on which kings and armies live.

Does any of this matter today? In 2013 the economists Stelios Michalopoulos and Elias Papaioannou compared the historical homelands of African ethnic groups with satellite images of light at night, a measure of present-day economic activity. They documented "a strong association between pre-colonial ethnic political centralization and regional development," which holds even between neighbouring homelands with different political histories. [87] The finding is evidence about capacity, not a ranking of virtue. A centralised kingdom could also be an efficient machine for raiding its neighbours, as the next section shows; a society without kings could be freer and fairer to its own members. But arrangements of authority made centuries ago still shape where roads, schools and markets are easiest to build.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

Two opposite stories about African politics before colonial rule are still widely told.

The first is colonial. It says that Africans lived in "tribes" — small, timeless, bounded groups, each under a chief — and had no states worth the name. The evidence of this chapter alone is enough to correct it. Stanley found a kingdom with a prime minister, provincial governors, appointed and hereditary chiefs, royal women with their own courts and an army that could muster tens of thousands. [11][75] Asante had a constitution of councils and oaths and a foreign office. [81] And where there were no chiefs, as in many Igbo communities, the colonial state had to invent them. [83] The "tribe with a chief" was less a description of Africa than a requirement of the people who wanted to govern it cheaply.

The second story is its mirror. In answering colonial contempt, it says that Africa was a continent of kings and empires, and it lists Mali, Kush, Great Zimbabwe, Buganda and Asante as if they were the whole. That story is also wrong. Many

Africans lived in societies that deliberately did without kings, or kept them small. [82][84] The very studies by Alsan and by Michalopoulos and Papaioannou depend on the fact that political centralisation varied widely among Africa's peoples; that variation is what they measure. [86][87] To count only the kingdoms is to accept the colonial measure of what counts as civilisation — and to erase the Igbo assembly, the council of elders and the age grade as political achievements in their own right.

The evidence corrects both stories in the same direction: towards variety. Africans did not lack political ideas. They had many, and they argued about them.

Who Carried the Weight

Power organised this well was also organised to take.

Buganda's strength rested in part on war. Its armies raided in the dry seasons and returned with cattle, women and captives; neighbouring Busoga sent slaves as tribute. [75] Stanley's estimate of Mutesa's war camp in 1875 counted, alongside the fighting men, some 50,000 women and "about as many children and slaves of both sexes." [11]

The Kabaka's power over life was real. Between 31 January 1885 and 27 January 1887, Kabaka Mwanga II ordered the execution of 22 Catholic and 23 Anglican converts, many of them members of his own court, at a time when Christian and Muslim factions were competing for influence and European powers were pressing in. [79] Kagwa himself narrowly escaped. [77] The Uganda Martyrs are now commemorated every 3 June. Their deaths show what an arrangement built around one man's will could do when that man felt threatened.

Asante's achievement also had its costs. Under Osei Kwame (1777–1803) the sale of Asante citizens into slavery was banned, but captives taken in war from other peoples could still be enslaved. The historian Ivor Wilks quotes Asantehene Osei Bonsu's words to a British envoy in 1820: "I cannot make war to

catch slaves in the bush, like a thief. My ancestors never did so. But if I fight a king and kill him when he is insolent, then certainly I must have his gold, and his slaves, and the people are mine too." [81] The king drew a moral line around his own people and his own way of making war. Those on the other side of the line carried the weight.

Societies without kings were not free of hierarchy either. In Igbo communities, law began with the *umunna*, a male line of descent headed by its eldest men. [83] Every grammar of power assigns some letters to the margins.

The Letter Principle

A people can be well organised and still unjust; it can be loosely organised and still just. The question of grammar is not only "how much power is gathered?" but "who may question it, who may leave it, and what stands above the person who holds it?" The Golden Stool answered the last question with an object: the nation's soul, placed where no king could sit. The Igbo assembly answered the first with a practice: no one speaks for everyone. Buganda answered the second, too often, with force. None of these answers was perfect. Each was a serious attempt to solve a problem every society faces, and each belongs to the inheritance of Africans who are still trying to solve it.

Questions for Reflection

1. The chiefs of Buganda examined Stanley before the Kabaka would receive him. What do the rules of access to power in your country — who may see a leader, and how — say about where authority really lies?
2. The Golden Stool places the nation above any king. What in your society plays that role today, and does it actually restrain the people who hold office?
3. Buganda and Bunyoro tell different stories about how Buganda began. When two communities remember the same

past differently, how should a historian — or a citizen — handle it?

4. Many Igbo communities governed themselves without kings. Is a decentralised arrangement a weakness, a strength, or both? Give an example from a church, school, company or village you know.
5. The research of Michalopoulos and Papaioannou links precolonial political centralisation to present-day development. What would you need to know before concluding that centralisation is "better"?

* * *

By the 1870s, the grammars of African power were many and old: kingdoms with ministers and queen mothers, unions bound by a sacred stool, villages that refused to bow to any one man. They had their brilliance and their cruelties. They were also about to meet forces that would test every one of them.

The first of those forces had been at work for centuries already, on the coasts and across the desert. The next chapter turns to the markets of captivity, and to a king of Kongo who wrote letters to Portugal begging for the trade in his people to stop.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 6

The Markets of Captivity

> *"Sire, Your Highness knows that our kingdom is losing its way, and we must provide the solution that this situation calls for."*
>
> — Afonso I, King of Kongo, to João III of Portugal, 1526

In 1526 the king of Kongo sat down to write to the king of Portugal.

His name was Nzinga Mbemba, and he had ruled since 1509 under his baptismal name, Afonso. His kingdom, centred on the town of Mbanza Kongo in what is now northern Angola, had been in contact with Portugal for more than forty years. Its nobles studied in Lisbon; Portuguese priests taught in its capital; its ambassadors travelled to Europe. Afonso was a Christian king who corresponded with his fellow monarch as an equal, and he had a complaint. [89]

"The cause of our troubles," he wrote, "is the excessive permissiveness with which your trading agents and officials allow the men who come to this kingdom to establish shops and sell merchandise." Portuguese traders were scattering through his kingdom, and his own vassals were renouncing their obedience "because they have a greater abundance of goods available to them than we do." [88]

Then he came to the worse harm. "We do not consider this harm as terrible as what we suffer each day when these traders carry away our native-born countrymen and the children of our nobles and vassals as well as relatives of ours. This continues because thieves and unscrupulous men, driven by their greed for goods from your kingdom, snatch them and sell them to these traders. Sire, this corruption and depravity has reached such a level that our homeland is becoming completely depopulated." What Kongo needed, he wrote, was priests and teachers, not more goods. "Please instruct your trading agents to send neither

traders nor trading goods here because we do not wish to carry out trade and export slaves." [88]

It is one of the earliest surviving documents in which an African ruler describes the Atlantic slave trade in his own words. It is, quite literally, a letter in conflict: a king writing against a market that was dissolving the bonds between him and his people.

It is also more complicated than it first appears. Afonso was not an abolitionist. He was a king trying to control who could be sold, by whom and to whom. His letter opens the hardest subject in this book. How did the trades in human beings work — the Atlantic trade, and the older trades across the Sahara and the Indian Ocean — who took part, who resisted, and what did they do to the relationships between people that every society depends on?

Three Trades

There was not one slave trade but several, and they overlapped in time and place.

The oldest ran north across the Sahara and down the Nile. Chapter 3 found captives in the contracts of Timbuktu and among the goods that crossed the desert alongside gold. Estimates are uncertain and contested; the historian Paul Lovejoy has estimated that some six million enslaved Africans were taken across the Sahara between 650 and 1500, and the trade continued into the nineteenth century. [93]

A second ran across the Indian Ocean and the Red Sea, from the Horn and the Swahili coast to Arabia, the Persian Gulf and India. It grew sharply in the nineteenth century, after Said bin Sultan, the ruler of Oman, made Zanzibar his capital and built a plantation economy of cloves and coconuts that demanded enslaved labour. [94] Its caravans reached deep into the interior. When Stanley arrived at Mutesa's court in 1875, the Kabaka's chief drummer and engineer was a man from Zanzibar. [11]

The best known and most closely counted is the Atlantic trade. The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database, edited by the historians David Eltis and David Richardson from surviving shipping records, estimates that between 1525 and 1866 some 12.5 million Africans were shipped across the Atlantic, of whom 10.7 million survived the crossing to be landed in the Americas. Only about 388,000 of them were taken directly to North America; the rest were landed in the Caribbean and South America. [90] The editors are careful to call these figures estimates. [90] Behind every one of them is a person with a name that was usually not recorded.

A Christian King and a Market in People

Afonso's letter has often been read as a simple protest against the trade. The fuller record shows a king who was part of it.

Kongo had slavery before the Portuguese arrived. Afonso expanded his kingdom by war, and captives taken in his campaigns were enslaved and moved to the capital, where their labour helped to centralise royal power. In 1512, after a campaign against the kingdom of Ndongo to the south, he wrote to the Portuguese king that he had sent him 410 slaves. By the 1510s he had an arrangement under which Portugal provided military help in exchange for a share of the captives taken in his wars. Enslaved people became a currency with which Kongo paid for goods and for the education of its nobles in Lisbon. [89]

Kongolese law drew lines. Freeborn Kongolese could not lawfully be sold or enslaved, and enslaved women could not be exported. What alarmed Afonso in 1526 was that these lines were being crossed. Kongolese nobles were trading directly with Portuguese merchants, bypassing the royal monopoly, and paying for imports by exporting slaves — some of them freeborn Kongolese kidnapped for the purpose. [89] His response was regulation, not abolition. He insisted on Kongolese law and set up a committee of Kongolese and Portuguese merchants to check

that each person offered for sale had been lawfully enslaved. [89]

None of this makes his letter less true. The traders were kidnapping his people; his kingdom was being drained; Portugal's demand was the engine of the market. But the letter shows the trade from the inside of an African state that both profited from it and was being undone by it.

The Line Around Our People

Afonso's distinction between his own freeborn subjects and captives taken from others appears again and again across Africa's kingdoms.

In Benin, as Chapter 4 noted, the oba prohibited the sale of male slaves after 1516, keeping them for his army. [69] In Asante, the sale of Asante citizens into slavery was banned under Osei Kwame (1777–1803), while war captives from other peoples could still be enslaved. [81] In Buganda, Kabakas such as Suna banned the sale of any Muganda to foreigners; most of the enslaved in Buganda came from neighbouring peoples such as the Banyoro and Basoga. [75]

Each kingdom drew a line around its own people and placed outsiders on the other side of it. The line protected some lives. It also defined who could be sold. The idea of "Africans" as a single people was not available to the people inside this history; the categories that mattered were kin and stranger, subject and captive, believer and unbeliever. A market in people turns on such lines — and, as the next section shows, it eventually erases them.

The Gun and the Captive

The economist Nathan Nunn asked whether the slave trades help to explain Africa's economic position today. Using shipping records and documents that record the ethnic origins of the enslaved, he estimated how many people were taken from the territory of each modern African country. He found "a robust

negative relationship between the number of slaves exported from a country and current economic performance," and argued that the evidence suggests the trades had an adverse effect on development. [91]

With the political scientist Leonard Wantchekon, Nunn then looked for the mechanism. They began from the historical record. Early in the trade, captives were taken mainly through state-organised raids and wars. But insecurity spread. To defend oneself, a person needed weapons, which could be bought from European or slave merchants; to buy weapons, one needed captives; and captives were often obtained by kidnapping and small-scale violence close to home. In time, as they summarise the evidence, "individuals — even friends and family members — began to turn on one another, kidnapping, tricking, and selling each other into slavery." [92]

The historian Walter Hawthorne, writing of the Upper Guinea coast, concluded that the Atlantic trade's effects "penetrated deep into the social fabric … beyond the level of the state and to the level of the village and household," so that "in many areas, the slave trade pitted neighbor against neighbor." [92] In the 1850s, at Atorkor in what is now Ghana, a chief who was also a slave trader arranged with a merchant named Dokutsu to have a whole drumming group of forty men sold. The drummers were invited aboard a European ship to perform, given rum, and carried away to the Americas. [92]

There is harder evidence too. In the 1840s the linguist Sigismund Koelle interviewed formerly enslaved people in Freetown, Sierra Leone, about how they had lost their freedom. Of 144 whose answers Nunn and Wantchekon tabulate, about 40 per cent had been kidnapped, about a quarter taken in war, 16 per cent enslaved through a judicial process — and almost 20 per cent sold or tricked by a relative or friend. [92]

Nunn and Wantchekon then compared modern survey data with the historical intensity of the trade by ethnic group. They found that people whose ancestors were heavily raided are less trusting today — of their relatives, their neighbours and their local

government — and that most of the effect works through "factors that are internal to the individual, such as cultural norms, beliefs, and values." [92] Before a letter could fear the stranger, it learned to fear the neighbour. And the habit outlived the trade.

A Witness and His Critics

The most famous African voice from the Atlantic trade belongs to a man known for most of his life as Gustavus Vassa. In 1789 he published *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano*, which went through nine editions in his lifetime and helped turn British opinion against the trade. [97] In it he described his childhood in the Igbo village of Essaka, in a family whose father himself owned slaves, and how, at about the age of eleven, he and his sister were seized while alone in the family compound, separated and sold from owner to owner towards the coast. [97] The scene contains the whole system in miniature: a household that held slaves, a village that guarded its children against kidnappers, and two children taken anyway.

In 1999 the literary historian Vincent Carretta, preparing a new edition, found that a London parish register recorded Vassa's baptism as "a Black, born in Carolina," and that a 1773 ship's muster also gave an American birthplace. He argued that the African childhood may have been constructed for effect. Other scholars, noting how many details of the narrative Carretta himself was able to corroborate, have concluded that the weight of evidence supports an African birth, and in 2025 the historian Paul Lovejoy proposed a location for Essaka in present-day Abia State. [97]

The argument is unresolved, and it should be held open rather than settled by preference. What is not in doubt is that Equiano was enslaved, that he bought his freedom, and that he turned the experience of the trade into testimony that changed minds. A witness can be cross-examined and still matter.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

Two slogans still compete in arguments about the slave trade. One says: “Africans sold Africans.” The other answers: “Europeans did it all.” Each is used to end a conversation. The evidence opens it again.

The first slogan is true in a narrow sense and false in every sense that matters. African rulers, merchants and kidnappers did sell people to European traders; Afonso’s own letters show it. [88][89] But “Africans” is the wrong word. The people who sold and the people who were sold did not belong to a single community with shared interests. A Kongolese king selling Ndongo war captives, a chief at Atorkor selling forty drummers, a stranger tricked into a house near a port and sold to a ship: these were acts by particular people against other particular people, inside a market whose demand came from across the ocean. [89][92] The slogan erases the captive, the protesting king and the family that hid from raiders, and makes the whole continent a single guilty party.

The second slogan is false in a different way. European states and merchants created and financed the Atlantic demand, built the forts, sailed the ships and owned the plantations that consumed the lives. Without that demand, the Atlantic trade would not have existed. But Europeans rarely captured people inland themselves. The trade worked through African states and African intermediaries, who negotiated prices, set terms and sometimes, like Benin, Asante and Buganda, restricted what could be sold. [69][75][81] To say that Africans had no part in it is to deny that they had any agency at all — the same denial that colonial writers made in the other direction.

What the evidence shows is a system of incentives with many actors and very unequal power. Demand from the Americas and Arabia; guns and goods that made raiding pay; kings who tried to control the trade and nobles who evaded them; neighbours who learned that a stranger, or a relative, could be turned into money. Responsibility in such a system is real, and it is shared unequally.

That is harder to put on a placard. It is also the only account that explains why a market so destructive lasted so long.

The East African Caravans

In the nineteenth century, as the Atlantic trade was being suppressed, the eastern trade reached its height, and it reached the Great Lakes.

Its best-known figure is Hamad bin Muhammad al-Murjabi, known as Tippu Tip, born in Zanzibar around 1832 to a family of Arab and Swahili traders. He led expeditions into the interior in search of ivory and slaves, and by the 1880s ruled a large territory in the eastern Congo, centred on Kasongo, while remaining loyal to the sultan of Zanzibar. He supplied and guided European explorers, Stanley among them. With the proceeds of the caravans he bought clove plantations on Zanzibar: by 1895, according to the historian Abdul Sheriff, he had acquired "seven 'shambas' [plantations] and 10,000 slaves." [95]

The caravans traded in ivory and in people together. Chapter 7 returns to how the campaign against this trade became one of Europe's justifications for conquering the same region.

The Ones Who Refused

The captives did not accept their fate, and neither did every ruler.

South of Kongo, the kingdom of Ndongo faced Portuguese armies operating from Luanda, which waged war by burning villages and taking hostages, and hired Imbangala warbands who raided for slaves. In 1624 a daughter of the royal house, Njinga Mbande, became its ruler. When the Portuguese drove her from Ndongo, she allied with the Imbangala, conquered the neighbouring kingdom of Matamba, and in 1641 joined the Dutch West India Company, which had seized Luanda, to fight the Portuguese. She sent messengers to encourage enslaved people to flee Portuguese plantations and join her. She ruled Matamba until her death in 1663 and is remembered in Angola for her political and military skill. [96] But in Matamba she also worked to

expand the slave trade, using its profits to finance her wars. [96] Resistance to Portugal was not resistance to slavery as such. Her story shows a ruler using every alliance available to keep her kingdom out of a conqueror's hands, in a world where no option was clean.

Others resisted with whatever they had. Some of Koelle's informants had been sold by kin, and yet lived to describe it, and their testimony is how we know. [92] Afonso wrote his letters. [88] And every enslaved person who kept a language, a song, a name or a faith alive across an ocean refused the market's central claim: that a human being could be reduced to a price.

The Letter Principle

A market in people does more than remove letters from the page. It changes the grammar for those who remain. When a neighbour can be sold, every neighbour becomes a risk. When a relative can profit from your capture, the family itself becomes a place of danger. Afonso saw this in 1526: goods from abroad were dissolving the obedience that held his kingdom together. Nunn and Wantchekon measured its echo four centuries later in the answers of ordinary people to a simple question about trust. When a system rewards betrayal more than cooperation, moral speeches alone cannot make the letters cooperate. Only a different system can.

Questions for Reflection

1. Afonso protested the trade while also selling war captives. How should we judge a leader who fights one injustice while taking part in another?
2. Kongo, Benin, Asante and Buganda each protected their own people from sale while selling others. Where do you see lines drawn today between "our people" and outsiders, and what do those lines permit?

3. Nunn and Wantchekon found that the slave trade still shapes trust in neighbours and local government. Do you recognise patterns of mistrust in your own community? Where do you think they come from?
4. Why are slogans such as “Africans sold Africans” and “Europeans did it all” so attractive? What does each one allow its speaker to avoid?
5. What would it take to rebuild trust in a community where people have learned that cooperation is dangerous?

* * *

The markets of captivity did not end at once. The Atlantic trade was suppressed in the nineteenth century, the eastern trade later, and slavery inside Africa later still. But the damage did not end with the trade. It had changed how people looked at strangers, at neighbours and at those in power.

The next chapter turns to the conquest that followed, when European powers, some of them claiming to end slavery, drew lines across the continent — and to what those lines did to the living worlds they crossed, including the kingdoms of the Great Lakes.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 7

Lines Drawn Across Living Worlds

> *"Let it be admitted at the outset that European brains, capital, and energy have not been, and never will be, expended in developing the resources of Africa from motives of pure philanthropy."*
>
> — Frederick Lugard, *The Dual Mandate in British Tropical Africa*, 1922

On 10 March 1900, at Mengo, the capital of Buganda, a document was signed in English and Luganda. [98] On one side stood Sir Harry Johnston, Her Majesty's Special Commissioner for the Uganda Protectorate. On the other stood the regents and chiefs who governed for the infant Kabaka, Daudi Chwa, among them the *Katikkiro*, Apolo Kagwa, whom Chapter 5 met as a page, a convert and a historian. [98][77]

The agreement began by drawing a line. Its first article traced the boundary of the "Kingdom of Uganda" from the Ripon Falls along the Victoria Nile, across lakes and up rivers, around islands, until it returned to its starting point. Its ninth article divided the kingdom into twenty counties, each under a chief chosen by the Kabaka's government but approved by the British representative. [98]

Then the agreement divided the land. Assuming the kingdom covered 19,600 square miles, it assigned 1,500 square miles of forest to the colonial administration, and 9,000 square miles of "waste and uncultivated land" to Her Majesty's Government. It allotted private estates to the Kabaka, the queen mother, the princes and princesses, the regents and the county chiefs. And "one thousand chiefs and private landowners" were to receive the estates they already held, computed at an average of eight square miles each: 8,000 square miles in all. [98]

It also imposed a tax. Every house, hut or dwelling would pay three rupees a year, and every gun the same; where coin was

scarce, the tax could be paid “in produce or in labour.” [98] And it set the terms of the kingdom’s survival. Britain would recognise the Kabaka as “native ruler” only “so long as” the Kabaka, chiefs and people conformed to its laws and cooperated loyally; the Lukiiko would elect future kings, but no one would be recognised whose election Britain had not approved. [98]

With a few pages of articles, a ruling class of chiefs became a class of landowners, a king became a ruler on conditions, a free people became taxpayers, and most of the land the farmers lived on became, in law, someone else’s. Nobody needed a battle at Mengo. The battles had already been fought.

This chapter is about such lines: borders on maps, but also lines in land registers, tax rolls and chains of command. How did conquest change who held authority, who owned land and who had to work, and how did Africans resist, bargain with and reshape the new order?

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

Ask almost anyone how Africa’s borders were made and the answer comes quickly: in 1884 and 1885, at a conference in Berlin, European statesmen sat around a map of Africa and drew lines across it with rulers, ignoring the people who lived there.

The conference was real, and it mattered. Fourteen countries met at the invitation of the German chancellor, Otto von Bismarck, at the request of King Leopold II of Belgium. No African ruler was invited. [99] The General Act they signed on 26 February 1885 recognised Leopold’s claims in the Congo basin, guaranteed free trade there, committed the powers to “[striving] for the suppression of slavery,” and laid down the principle of “effective occupation”: a claim to African territory would be recognised only if the claimant established authority there. [99] The rules turned a scramble into a race with a referee.

But the conference did not draw Africa’s borders. Historians of Africa have said so for decades. Simon Katzenellenbogen titled his study of the subject “It didn’t happen at Berlin,” and the

standard history of the conference, written by Sybil Crowe in 1942, shows how little it decided. [100] In 2024 the political scientists Jack Paine, Xiaoyan Qiu and Joan Ricart-Huguet examined all 107 of Africa's bilateral borders, dating when each first appeared and when it was last substantially revised. Half of them "did not exist in any form until 1891," six years after the conference ended. Half were modified in major ways after 1908, more than two decades later. Apart from the Congo, the conference set no borders at all. [100][99]

Nor were most borders random. Europeans knew little of Africa in 1885, and they cared little for its people. But to make a claim stick against a rival, they had to learn the ground. Under the principle that a treaty with an African ruler gave a power his whole domain, they signed a flurry of treaties with African rulers and often followed the frontiers of existing states. Paine, Qiu and Ricart-Huguet found that in 62 per cent of borders, the line was settled in accordance with the location of precolonial states or other existing political frontiers. Rivers and lakes formed the main feature of 63 per cent of borders; straight lines were the main feature of only 37 per cent, most of them in thinly populated regions such as the Sahara. The borders of the Great Lakes region, they note, "are inexplicable without referencing the lakes and precolonial states." [100] African rulers, who knew their domains better than any European, could influence where the lines fell. [100]

This does not make the borders harmless. Many societies without kings were divided, because there was no state frontier to follow. In 2016 the economists Stelios Michalopoulos and Elias Papaioannou found that ethnic homelands split by colonial borders have suffered more frequent, severe and lasting political violence, and that people from split groups are economically disadvantaged. [101] The damage was real. What the evidence corrects is the picture of how it happened: not one afternoon in Berlin, but decades of treaties, surveys, wars and bargains, in which Africans were present, sometimes as negotiators and more often as victims.

Why does the difference matter? Because the Berlin myth makes the partition a single European act that Africans merely suffered. The fuller story shows a process with many points at which African rulers fought, negotiated or allied — and so it also prepares us for a harder question in the next chapter. If the borders were not fixed in a day, why did independent Africa decide to keep them?

The Winners at Mengo

The 1900 agreement was not simply imposed on Buganda. It was negotiated, and it had winners.

Before 1900, Chapter 5 showed, Buganda was close to an absolute monarchy, and its Lukiiko was an advisory council around the king. The agreement gave the Lukiiko statutory recognition and greatly enhanced its power at the expense of the Kabaka, who was in any case a child. [75][98] It made the chiefs who had negotiated it — led by Apolo Kagwa and largely Protestant — the core of the new order. Britain sent few officials and relied on these chiefs to collect taxes and keep order; for decades they were preferred for their political skill, their Christianity and their good relations with the British. [77] The land settlement turned their estates into private property. [98]

Others lost. With 8,000 square miles assigned to a thousand chiefs and landowners, most farmers now lived on land registered to someone else. Bunyoro lost territory to its rival. [78] [98]

An agreement among elites can be a real negotiation and still be paid for by people who were not in the room. That pattern would outlive the protectorate.

Allies and Agents

In the Great Lakes region, conquest did not come only from outside. It came partly through African alliances and African agents.

To the north-west, Bunyoro's Omukama Kabalega, who had ruled since 1870, offered some of the most sustained resistance to British and Egyptian expansion of any African monarch of his time. [103] He fought British-led forces through the 1890s; his reign ended in 1899, he was sent into exile, and he died in 1923 at Jinja, on his way home. [103] When the 1900 agreement listed Buganda's twenty counties, two of them, Buyaga and Bugangaizi, were lands that Bunyoro regarded as its own. [98] [78] Bunyoro called them the "lost counties," and would regain them only after a referendum in 1964, as Chapter 8 recounts. [78]

To the east, the British used a Ganda general to extend their rule. Semei Kakungulu, a Protestant commander from the Buganda court, conquered Bukedi and Busoga on the protectorate's behalf, hoping to be made their king. [104] Britain preferred to rule through officials in its own pay and limited him to an estate of some twenty square miles around what became Mbale. He was also made president of a Lukiiko created for Busoga on the Ganda model, and was later dismissed. [104] A Ganda institution had been carried, by a Ganda general, into a society that had never had it.

Kakungulu's life holds the whole ambiguity. He was an agent of British conquest and a builder of his own power, a man who used the colonial order and was used by it. He ended his life founding a community of Ugandans who practised Judaism, the Abayudaya, an act of religious independence from the missionaries who had first taught him to read. [104] There is no simple word for such a person, and there should not be.

The Stool That Was Not Surrendered

In Asante, the British had already deported the Asantehene Prempeh I in 1896. In 1900 the governor of the Gold Coast, Sir Frederick Hodgson, demanded to be allowed to sit on the Golden Stool, and ordered a search for it. [80]

Chapter 5 explained what he was asking. No Asantehene sat on the stool; it held the spirit of the nation, living, dead and yet to

be born. [80] To demand to sit on it was to demand the soul of the nation as a seat for a foreign governor. War followed. It was led by Yaa Asantewaa, queen mother of Ejisu, an office that carried responsibility for protecting the stool and advising on the choice of kings, whom regional Asante rulers chose as their war leader — the only woman known to have held that role in Asante history. [105] From March 1900 her forces besieged the British in the fort at Kumasi for months, until a relief force of some 1,400 broke the siege. Yaa Asantewaa and her closest advisers were captured and exiled to the Seychelles, and Asante was annexed. [105]

The British won the war. They never got the stool. [80] The Asante had distinguished, as Chapter 5 showed, between the office and the person who held it. They could lose a king to exile and keep the nation's soul hidden, because the soul had never been in the king.

The Grammar of Indirect Rule

Britain governed much of its African empire through African rulers, and its most influential theorist was the British colonial administrator Frederick Lugard. In *The Dual Mandate in British Tropical Africa* (1922) he was candid about motive: "European brains, capital, and energy have not been, and never will be, expended in developing the resources of Africa from motives of pure philanthropy." Europe was in Africa, he wrote, "for the mutual benefit of her own industrial classes, and of the native races in their progress to a higher plane," and it was the aim of "civilised administration to fulfil this dual mandate." [102]

Indirect rule was cheap. It used existing kings and chiefs to collect taxes, judge cases and keep order, under a British officer. Where strong states existed, as in Buganda, it could preserve their outward forms. But the rulers it preserved were now accountable upwards, to the colonial officer, more than downwards, to the councils and customs that had once restrained them. The Kabaka's throne now depended on Britain's

approval. [98] The grammar looked familiar. Its subject had changed.

Where there were no chiefs, indirect rule had to invent them. In south-eastern Nigeria, the British appointed "warrant chiefs" among Igbo and neighbouring communities whose political traditions, as Chapter 5 showed, rested on assemblies and elders rather than kings. [83] In 1929, when a colonial officer began counting people and property in the Bende district, the women of Oloko suspected that direct taxation, imposed on men the year before, would now be extended to them. Thousands of women from at least six ethnic groups converged on the warrant chiefs and the Native Courts. They used an established practice of public shaming known as "sitting on a man." Many warrant chiefs were forced to resign and sixteen Native Courts were attacked; more than fifty women were killed. In 1930 the government abolished the warrant chief system and appointed women to the Native Courts. [107] The women of the Women's War had defended an older grammar against a forged one, and won.

Water Against Bullets

In German East Africa, now mainland Tanzania, conquest took a harsher form. Germany levied head taxes from 1898 and relied on forced labour. In 1902 the governor ordered villages to grow cotton for export, each with a quota, on land where the crop often failed. [106]

In 1905 a spirit medium named Kinjikitile Ngwale gave the resistance a unifying idea: a medicine, *maji*, water, that would turn German bullets to water. His followers, armed mostly with spears and arrows, attacked small outposts and damaged cotton plants. The rising drew in many peoples — Matumbi, Ngindo, Ngoni, Yao and others. [106] Germany crushed it with scorched-earth tactics. Between 1905 and 1907, between 75,000 and 300,000 people died, overwhelmingly from the famine that followed, which scholars have described as genocidal. [106]

It is easy to treat the belief in maji as the tragic error of the rising. It was also a political innovation: a shared idea that allowed people divided by language, lineage and old rivalries to act as one against a common enemy. The water did not stop the bullets. But the idea had done something no single chief could do: it made allies of strangers.

Tax, Labour and the Railway

Colonial rule was expected to pay for itself, and Africans paid. A hut tax had to be met in coin, which meant selling crops or labour to those who had coin; and where coin was lacking, as the Buganda agreement allowed, it could be paid in labour directly. [98]

The great project of British East Africa was the Uganda Railway, authorised by Parliament in 1896 to run from Mombasa to Lake Victoria. Construction began at Mombasa in 1896 and reached Kisumu, on the lake, in 1901; its entire original length of some 1,060 kilometres lay in what became Kenya. More than 30,000 labourers were contracted from British India, mostly from Punjab and Gujarat, and worked in conditions that historians describe as extremely harsh. [108] A railway built from the coast to the lake pointed the economy of the interior towards the coast and the export trade. Development and extraction ran on the same rails.

Lugard listed what he believed colonial rule had brought: railways and roads, the reclamation of swamps, fair trade, an end to the slave trade and to inter-communal war. [102] Some of those things were real. Railways were built; the external slave trades were suppressed. But the same rule took land by agreement and by force, imposed taxes payable in labour, invented chiefs and starved a rebellion. The mandate was dual in a way Lugard did not intend.

The Letter Principle

A border is only the most visible line conquest drew. The deeper lines ran through land registers, tax rolls and chains of command, and they changed the relationships between letters. A chief who had answered to his people now answered to a district officer. A farmer who had held land through clan and chief now lived on someone else's mailo. A queen mother could raise an army, and a council of women could unseat a forged chief, but the final word lay elsewhere. Conquest did not abolish African grammar. It subordinated it. Many of the old forms survived, which is why the change was so easy to miss — and so hard, later, to undo.

Questions for Reflection

1. The 1900 Buganda Agreement turned chiefs into landowners and most farmers into tenants. Who owns the land in your community today, and how did that arrangement come about?
2. The Berlin Conference did not draw Africa's borders, yet the myth persists. Why might a simple story of blame be more attractive than a complicated true one?
3. Semei Kakungulu helped the British conquer eastern Uganda while pursuing his own ambitions. How should we remember Africans who allied with colonial powers?
4. The Asante kept the Golden Stool even after losing the war. What do you think a community must protect, even in defeat?
5. The women of the 1929 Women's War forced the abolition of warrant chiefs. What forms of collective action exist in your community, and when have they worked?

* * *

By the 1920s, the lines had settled. Most of Africa lay inside borders drawn over three decades of treaties and wars; most Africans paid taxes to governments they had not chosen, through

chiefs who answered to foreign officers. The old grammar survived, bent to new purposes.

The next chapter follows the moment when the foreigners left — in Ghana in 1957 and in Uganda in 1962 — and asks what the new nations inherited, what they chose to keep, and what happened to the kingdoms of the Great Lakes when independence came.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 8

Freedom with Inherited Machinery

> *“From now on, today, we must change our attitudes and our minds. We must realise that from now on we are no longer a colonial but free and independent people.”*
>
> — Kwame Nkrumah, Ghana’s independence night, 6 March 1957

On the night of 6 March 1957, Kwame Nkrumah stood before a crowd in Accra as the Gold Coast became the independent state of Ghana. [109][45] “At long last, the battle has ended!” he began. “And thus, Ghana, your beloved country is free forever!” [109]

He thanked the youth, the farmers, the women and the ex-servicemen who had fought for it. Then he said something that is easy to pass over in the celebration: “From now on, today, we must change our attitudes and our minds. We must realise that from now on we are no longer a colonial but free and independent people.” Freedom, he warned, “also entails hard work.” He told the crowd that “our independence is meaningless unless it is linked up with the total liberation of Africa,” and he ended with a promise: “Today, from now on, there is a new African in the world!” [109]

Nkrumah understood that a flag could change at midnight and a mind could not. So could a constitution, a currency or a name. What came with the new flag — the borders, the civil service, the army, the laws, the railway lines running from mine and farm to port — did not change at midnight. Independent Africa inherited a machine built for other purposes and was asked to drive it somewhere new.

This chapter is about that inheritance. It is also about choices. Some of what independent Africa kept, it kept because it had no alternative. Some it kept deliberately. Some it broke, and some of

what it broke was its own. What did the new nations inherit, what did they decide to keep, and what did those decisions cost?

Uganda: A Kingdom Inside a Republic

Uganda became independent on 9 October 1962. [114] Its first prime minister was Milton Obote, a Lango from northern Uganda educated at Makerere, who had founded the Uganda People's Congress (UPC) in 1960 and represented it at the constitutional conference held by the British at Lancaster House in London in 1961. [113]

The independence settlement tried to fit the old grammar inside the new one. Buganda became a semi-autonomous part of a federal Uganda. Obote's UPC governed in coalition with Kabaka Yekka, the royalist party of Buganda. [111] In October 1963 Parliament elected Kabaka Mutesa II, by secret ballot, as Uganda's first president, a ceremonial office; the constitution provided for the president to be chosen from among the country's hereditary rulers. [111][114] For a moment, the kingdom of Chapter 5 and the republic of the twentieth century appeared to have found a sentence they could share.

It did not last. The coalition broke in 1964 over the "lost counties" that the 1900 agreement had placed inside Buganda. [98][111] Against Mutesa's will, a referendum was held, and the residents of Buyaga and Bugangaizi voted overwhelmingly to return to Bunyoro. [111][78] A line drawn at Mengo in 1900 had been redrawn by ballot sixty-four years later, and the partnership between kingdom and republic did not survive it.

The Crisis of 1966

In early 1966 Obote faced a challenge from inside his own party, including a parliamentary motion over allegations concerning the bank account of the army commander, Colonel Idi Amin. [112] On 24 February he suspended Mutesa as president, citing among other things the Kabaka's reaction to the referendum and his seeking of foreign military support; Mutesa later admitted to

having “sounded out” the British high commissioner and several African ambassadors. [112]

On 20 May the Lukiiko passed a resolution demanding that the national government leave Buganda’s soil within ten days. Mutesa later explained the reasoning: “We did not for a moment expect them to leave. The purpose was to bring a case against them for remaining.” [112] On 23 May the army cordoned off the Kabaka’s palace, the Lubiri, at Mengo. Early the next morning it attacked, under Amin’s direct command. [112] Within days the Kabaka and two bodyguards had crossed the border into Burundi; he went on to exile in Britain, where he died in 1969. [112]

The following year Obote introduced a new constitution. It abolished all of Uganda’s traditional kingdoms and made Uganda a republic. [112][114]

Two things happened in 1966 that are easy to confuse. A national government decided that a federal arrangement with a powerful kingdom could not hold. And a soldier trained by the colonial army — Amin had served in the King’s African Rifles from 1946 to 1962 [119] — used that army against Ugandan citizens on Ugandan soil, on the orders of a civilian government. The first was a political choice about grammar. The second taught the army what it could do, a lesson Chapter 9 follows.

In 1993 the government of Yoweri Museveni restored the kingdoms, but only as cultural institutions without political power, a status later set out in Article 246 of the 1995 constitution. [117] The office survived. Its powers did not.

The Blackboard at Léopoldville

If Uganda shows a kingdom struggling to fit inside a republic, the Congo shows what happened when the machinery was handed over almost without warning.

Belgium agreed to Congolese independence at a round-table conference in Brussels in January 1960, and the Republic of the Congo was proclaimed on 30 June, barely five months later. Minimal preparations had been made, and questions of

federalism and ethnic rivalry were unresolved. [120] At the independence ceremony in Léopoldville, King Baudouin presented the end of colonial rule as the culmination of the "civilising mission" begun by Leopold II — the king whose claims Chapter 7 saw recognised at Berlin. The new prime minister, Patrice Lumumba, answered with a speech recalling the humiliations of colonial rule. [120]

The day after the festivities, the Belgian commander of the army, the Force Publique, Lieutenant-General Émile Janssens, gathered the African non-commissioned officers of the capital's garrison. He told them that nothing would change under his command, and summed up the point on a blackboard: "Before Independence = After Independence." [120] On 5 July soldiers mutinied against their white officers, and the mutiny spread across the country. Lumumba dismissed Janssens and promoted every Black soldier by at least one rank; a sergeant-major became a major-general overnight. [120] Within weeks the mineral-rich province of Katanga had declared its own independence. [120]

What followed drew in Belgium, the United Nations, the United States and the Soviet Union. Lumumba appealed for Soviet support; Joseph-Désiré Mobutu, who had taken effective control of the army, seized power in a coup in September 1960; Lumumba was captured on 1 December, handed over to his enemies in Katanga and killed in January 1961. [120][121] In 2001 a group of historians appointed by the Belgian parliament concluded that the Belgian government had helped to oust him, insisted that he be arrested but not tried, and supported his transfer to Katanga "without ruling out ... the possibility that he might be executed there." [121] In 2022, when Lumumba's remains were returned to his family, the Belgian prime minister apologised "for the way in which the Belgian government influenced the decision to end the life of the country's first prime minister." [121]

Janssens's blackboard is the most honest statement of the colonial inheritance ever written. It was meant as a command. It

became a prophecy that Congolese soldiers refused, and then, under Mobutu, one that their own rulers fulfilled. The Congo's story belongs equally to the inheritance and to the choices made inside it, by Congolese politicians and soldiers as well as by outside powers. Chapter 9 returns to Mobutu.

Tanganyika: Breaking and Rebuilding

Not every new government kept what it found. Tanganyika, which became independent in 1961 and joined with Zanzibar to form Tanzania in 1964, made different choices.

Its leader, Julius Nyerere, was himself the son of a Zanaki chief, educated at Makerere and Edinburgh. [122] Six months after independence, his government abolished the posts and salaries of hereditary chiefs, whose positions conflicted with those of government officials and who were often regarded as too close to the colonial authorities. It also pursued the "Africanisation" of the civil service, paying off several hundred British officials; by the end of 1963 about half of senior and middle-grade posts were held by Africans, many of them insufficiently trained. [122] Nyerere, who translated Shakespeare's *Julius Caesar* into Swahili in 1961, made the coastal language of Chapter 4 a language of national government. [122]

He described independence in terms close to Nkrumah's: "You go through two stages in these colonial countries. One is when midnight comes; the clock strikes, and you are independent. Fine. But then begins a whole process of changing conditions and changing people." [122]

Uganda abolished its kings by force and restored them by statute. Tanganyika dismantled its chiefs by policy within months of independence. Neither path was free of cost, and the next chapter will show that Nyerere's Tanzania also became a one-party state. But the contrast makes the central point of this chapter. The inheritance was the same in kind. What was done with it differed, because people chose differently.

What Came With the Flag

Uganda's story is one country's. The inheritance was continental.

Borders. Chapter 7 showed that Africa's borders were made over decades, often following existing frontiers but sometimes splitting peoples apart, with lasting costs. [100][101] In 1962 every newly independent government held a territory whose shape had been settled by colonial treaties.

The state itself. The new governments took over administrations designed to keep order and collect revenue for a distant power, and armies raised for colonial purposes. In Uganda the army that attacked the Lubiri was commanded by a man trained in the colonial King's African Rifles. [112][119]

Chiefs and law. Indirect rule, Chapter 7 showed, had made chiefs answerable upwards to colonial officers. [98] Independence did not automatically make them answerable downwards again. The question of what to do with kings and chiefs — keep them, reform them or abolish them — confronted almost every new state, and Uganda answered it three times in thirty years: by federation in 1962, by abolition in 1967 and by cultural restoration in 1993. [111][114][117]

Economic geography. The railways ran from the interior to the ports, as the Uganda Railway ran from Lake Victoria to Mombasa. [108] Economies had been built to export crops and minerals. A new flag did not move a railway line.

None of these was a sentence. They were constraints: the page, the ink and the type already set, before the new writers sat down.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

It is often said that Africa's colonial borders were simply forced on Africans, who never had a say in keeping them. The record shows otherwise.

At independence there was a real debate about the shape of the continent. Nkrumah wanted a federation of all African states; in 1961 the so-called Casablanca group of states, led by Ghana,

pressed for political union, while the larger Monrovia group, led by Senegal's Léopold Senghor, wanted unity to come gradually through economic cooperation. [116] When the Organisation of African Unity was founded in 1963, total unity proved difficult to achieve. [116]

In July 1964 the OAU's heads of state met in Cairo and took up the question of borders directly. Their resolution began: "Considering that border problems constitute a grave and permanent factor of dissention." It noted the "extra-African manoeuvres aimed at dividing African States," and declared that "the borders of African States, on the day of their independence, constitute a tangible reality." Then it decided: "All Member States pledge themselves to respect the borders existing on their achievement of national independence." [115]

This was an African decision, made by African governments for reasons they stated plainly: border disputes were a permanent source of conflict, and outside powers would exploit them. The logic is easy to see. To redraw the map along ethnic or historical lines might have opened a generation of wars. It was also a choice with costs. It froze the divisions Chapter 7 described, and it committed new states to holding together territories whose peoples had not chosen to live together, often by force.

The correction is not that the borders were good, or that the OAU was wrong. It is that the inheritance was ratified. The colonial powers drew the lines; independent Africa decided to keep them. A constraint that is consciously accepted becomes, in part, a choice — and a choice can be revisited, revised or made to work better by the people who made it.

Between Blame and Responsibility

How much of what followed independence should be blamed on the inheritance, and how much on what Africans did with it? The question has been argued ever since, and the answer has political consequences.

In 2001 African governments launched the New Partnership for Africa's Development (NEPAD). Its framework document traced the continent's impoverishment, among other causes, to "colonial legacies," with the Cold War and the international economic system also contributing. [118] Critics attacked it from both sides. The Labour Resource and Research Institute, based in Namibia, complained in 2003 that NEPAD avoided words such as "imperialism" and "neo-colonialism," placed no responsibility on former colonial powers, and was also "soft and vague in its analysis of self-serving African elite who have plundered their countries." [118]

That double complaint is revealing. A document that blames only outsiders lets rulers off the hook. A document that blames only rulers forgets the machinery they were handed. Any honest account has to hold both, and in different proportions for different countries, decades and decisions.

Ghana itself shows how quickly the two became entangled. The country Nkrumah freed in 1957 became, by a constitutional amendment in 1964, a one-party state with Nkrumah as president for life. [110] The colonial state had been authoritarian; the independent state chose to remain so. Uganda took a similar road after 1966. [112][114] Inheritance explains how the tools were available. It does not explain why they were picked up.

The Letter Principle

A new writer who inherits a half-written page has two temptations. One is to blame every bad sentence on the previous author. The other is to pretend the page was blank. Independence in Africa was a new writer at an old desk. The borders, armies, offices and railways were real constraints, and many of them were imposed. But some were chosen, ratified and used, and some of the most damaging sentences of the independence era — the attack on a king's palace, the one-party constitution — were written by Africans in their own hand. To see

the inheritance clearly is not to excuse what came after. It is to know which parts of the page can still be rewritten, and by whom.

Questions for Reflection

1. Nkrumah said that independence required Africans to "change our attitudes and our minds." Which colonial habits of mind do you think survive in your country today?
2. Uganda tried three answers to the question of its kingdoms: federation, abolition and cultural restoration. What role, if any, should traditional institutions play in a modern state?
3. In 1964 African governments chose to keep colonial borders. Was that the right decision? What would you have advised, and why?
4. NEPAD was criticised for being too soft on former colonial powers and too soft on African elites. Can a single account of a nation's problems satisfy both criticisms?
5. Think of an institution you inherited — a school, a church, a business, a family arrangement. Which of its rules did you choose to keep, and which simply continued because no one changed them?

* * *

The new flags flew over old machinery. In some countries the machine was repaired and redirected; in many it was captured. The question of who would control the state, and for what purpose, became the central question of the decades after independence.

The next chapter follows what happened when power became an end in itself: the coups, the one-party states, the patrons of the Cold War, and the countries that found a different way.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 9

When Power Became Greater Than Purpose

> *"We can prove to the world that when the African is given a chance, he can show the world that he is somebody!"*
>
> — Kwame Nkrumah, 6 March 1957

On 25 January 1971, Uganda's president, Milton Obote, was in Singapore at a meeting of Commonwealth heads of government. In Kampala, soldiers loyal to the army commander, Idi Amin, moved to secure the capital and Entebbe. They sealed the airport to prevent Obote's return; tanks patrolled the streets; there was fighting in Jinja and at the police college. At 4.30 in the afternoon it was announced that the army and police under Amin's leadership controlled the entire country. [123]

Radio Uganda accused the fallen government of corruption, of policies that bred violence and of favouring some regions over others. The broadcast, it was reported, was met with cheering crowds in the capital. [123] Less than five years earlier, in May 1966, Obote had sent the same army, under the same commander, against the Kabaka's palace. [112]

The cheering did not last. Amin purged the army of soldiers from Obote's Langi and the Acholi; by 1972 some 5,000 had been killed. [123] In August 1972 he declared an "economic war" and ordered the expulsion of Uganda's Asians, most of them born in the country, and the seizure of their property. [119] Estimates of the number of Ugandans murdered during his eight years in power run as high as 300,000. [123] He was driven out in 1979 by Tanzanian forces and Ugandan exiles. [123]

Chapter 8 ended with an army trained by a colonial power being turned against citizens by a civilian government. Five years later the army turned on the government. The lesson Amin had learned at the Lubiri was that the gun decided. The lesson

Ugandans learned in 1971 was that cheering the fall of one ruler did not decide what kind of ruler came next.

This chapter asks how power in many independent African states became greater than the purposes it had been claimed for — independence, development, unity — and why some states escaped that pattern. It is a historical question. How such power feels to live under today belongs to the next book.

The Gun Enters Politics

Uganda's coup was not the first. On 13 January 1963, soldiers in Togo seized government buildings and arrested most of the cabinet; the country's first president, Sylvanus Olympio, was killed outside the United States embassy in Lomé. Among the coup leaders was Étienne Eyadéma, who would later rule Togo himself as Gnassingbé Eyadéma. [125]

On 24 February 1966, while Kwame Nkrumah was visiting China, army and police officers in Ghana overthrew him. Their National Liberation Council dissolved his party and Parliament and suspended the constitution. [126] The man who had promised "a new African in the world" in 1957 had by then made Ghana a one-party state with himself as president for life. [110] [126] His government had run up a large foreign debt; by 1963 Ghanaians were suffering shortages, and the party had increased its repression of opponents. [126] He never returned.

The pattern spread. According to the political scientists Jonathan Powell and Clayton Thyne, whose data cover every coup attempt in the world since 1950, Africa has seen 220 attempted coups, the most of any region, of which 109 succeeded. [124] The worst year was 1966, with seven coups. During the Cold War, Powell observed, "there was effectively an unwritten rule saying if you controlled the capital, you were recognized as legitimate." [124] The question "who controls the state?" was increasingly answered not at the ballot box, nor in the council of elders, but by whoever commanded the soldiers.

One Party, One Man

Where the army did not rule, the party often did. Ghana became a one-party state in 1964. [110] In Tanzania, Nyerere built a one-party state too: in the 1965 elections only candidates of the ruling party, TANU, could stand, though the party offered voters a choice between candidates in almost every seat, and several ministers lost. [122] Nyerere was admired across Africa for keeping Tanzania stable and unified when many of its neighbours were not; he was also accused of dictatorial governance for the one-party state and detention without trial, and blamed for economic mismanagement after the nationalisations of 1967. [122] In 1985 he stood down, and later supported Tanzania's transition to a multiparty system — a path few rulers of his generation chose. [122]

The arguments for the single party were not foolish. New states held together peoples divided by the borders Chapter 7 described; competitive parties, it was said, would become ethnic parties, and ethnic parties would tear the nation apart. But the single party removed the means by which a people could replace a government without violence. When it failed, as many did, the only remaining exits were the coup and the grave.

The Patron's Client

The Cold War made these regimes useful to outside powers, and their usefulness kept many of them in place.

The clearest case is Mobutu Sese Seko. Chapter 8 left him as the army officer who seized power in the Congo in 1960 and installed the government that handed Lumumba to his killers. [121][127] In 1965 he took power directly in a second coup. He made his Popular Movement of the Revolution the only legal party in 1967, renamed the country Zaire in 1971 and took a new name of his own. [127] His campaign of *authenticité* renamed Léopoldville as Kinshasa and Stanleyville as Kisangani, ordered citizens to replace European names with African ones, and

banned Western suits in favour of a tunic called the *abacost*. [127]

Some of this was genuine cultural decolonisation; the cities had carried the names of a Belgian king and a British explorer. But *authenticité* also wrapped a personal dictatorship in the language of African dignity. Mobutu was the object of a pervasive personality cult, distributed state wealth through a patronage network, and presided over widespread human rights abuses, while the economy suffered uncontrolled inflation, a large debt and repeated devaluations. [127] Because he was firmly anti-communist, he received strong military, diplomatic and economic support from the United States, France and Belgium for most of three decades. [127] He fell only in 1997, after the Cold War had ended, and died in exile months later. [127]

Uganda shows how fluid such patronage could be. In his first year Amin received military and financial support from Britain and Israel; within two years he had expelled the Israelis and turned to Libya's Muammar Gaddafi, to Mobutu, and to the Soviet Union and East Germany. [119] A ruler who needed a patron could usually find one. It was an African neighbour, not a superpower, that finally removed him: Nyerere's Tanzania, after Amin's forces invaded its territory, fought the war of 1978–79 that ended his rule. [122][123] The Cairo pledge of 1964 had committed African states to respect one another's borders; it had not anticipated a ruler like Amin.

Mobutu's story holds both halves of the argument this book keeps insisting on. Outside patrons armed and financed him. Congolese men and women staffed his ministries, wore his abacost and filled his party. A patron needs a client; a client needs a patron. Neither explanation is complete without the other.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

From these decades a single explanation of African politics became popular among scholars, journalists and aid agencies.

African states, it said, are “neopatrimonial”: behind the façade of modern institutions, a “Big Man” rules through personal networks, distributing state resources to clients and kinsmen in return for loyalty. The model was used to explain almost everything — trade policy, inflation, economic stagnation, poor infrastructure, the bias towards cities, the lack of development itself.

In 2015 the Malawian economist Thandika Mkandawire published a sustained critique in *World Politics*. He described neopatrimonialism as having become “the convenient, all purpose, and ubiquitous moniker for African governance.” After examining the evidence for its predictions, he concluded that while the concept describes real social practices, it “has little analytical content and no predictive value with respect to economic policy and performance.” [128] Countries described as neopatrimonial had followed very different policies and achieved very different results. A label that fits every case explains none of them.

The evidence of this chapter points the same way. If personal rule were simply the African condition, three things would be hard to explain. First, Botswana, discussed below, which has held free elections since 1966. [130] Second, Benin, where in 1990 a military ruler was stripped of power by a national conference of his own citizens. [132] Third, the decline of coups themselves: in the decade before 2021, according to Powell and Thyne’s data, Africa averaged fewer than one successful coup a year, compared with seven coups in 1966 alone. [124]

None of this means that patronage and personal rule were imaginary. Mobutu and Amin were real. What the evidence corrects is the idea that they were the inevitable expression of African culture. They were outcomes of particular choices, under particular pressures — Cold War money, armies without restraint, single parties without exits — and different choices produced different outcomes. Ancient Asante, Chapter 5 showed, could remove a king who ignored his council. [81] There was nothing un-African about holding power to account.

Botswana: The Chief Who Gave Up the Stool

In 1966 the British protectorate of Bechuanaland became independent as Botswana. The colonial power had invested very little in it, and it began with high inequality. [129][130] Over the following decades it achieved, according to the economists Daron Acemoglu, Simon Johnson and James Robinson, the highest rate of growth in income per head of any country in the world over a period of thirty-five years. [129]

Its first president was Seretse Khama, heir to the Ngwato chieftainship. While studying in Britain he married an Englishwoman, Ruth Williams; under pressure from apartheid South Africa, Britain banished the couple from the protectorate in 1950. [130][131] In 1956 they were allowed to return as private citizens after he renounced the chieftainship. He entered politics, and in 1966 became president. [131] A hereditary ruler surrendered his claim to rule by birth and then won power by election.

Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson offered several reasons for Botswana's success. Its precolonial Tswana institutions were relatively inclusive and placed constraints on political elites — by the nineteenth century, Tswana states governed through the *kgotla*, a community council. [129][130] British rule was light and did not destroy those institutions. After independence, maintaining property rights served the interests of the elite. Diamonds, discovered in 1967, created enough revenue that no group wanted to "rock the boat." And, they emphasised, the situation was reinforced by critical decisions made by its leaders, particularly Presidents Khama and Masire. [129][130] At independence, traditional chiefs and the kgotla were kept but placed under the national legal system. [130]

Botswana was not perfect. The Botswana Democratic Party governed without interruption from 1966, and the ruling party enjoyed institutional advantages. [130] But in the 2024 general election it was defeated, ending fifty-eight years in power, and handed over to the opposition. [130] Botswana shows what this

book has argued since Chapter 1: history shapes the arrangement, but people decide whether to keep it.

Adjustment and Opening

By the 1980s many African economies were in crisis. During that decade the International Monetary Fund and World Bank created loan packages for most countries in sub-Saharan Africa, conditional on "structural adjustment": privatisation, the liberalisation of trade and investment, and balanced budgets. [133] The results are still argued over; critics point out that growth in many African countries in the 1980s and 1990s fell below earlier rates and that adjustment had a contractive effect in most of them. [133] Whatever its merits, it meant that key economic decisions were now negotiated with lenders in Washington — a new kind of inheritance.

Then, as the Cold War ended, the patrons withdrew and the pressure from below grew. In Benin, President Mathieu Kérékou, who had seized power in a coup in 1972 and ruled under an officially Marxist–Leninist ideology, was forced by popular discontent to convene a national conference in February 1990. [132] The conference declared its own sovereignty. Kérékou called it a "civilian coup" but did not use force against it. In a session broadcast on national television, he confessed his regime's faults to the Archbishop of Cotonou, Isidore de Souza, and asked forgiveness. A new constitution was approved in December 1990, and in March 1991 Kérékou lost the presidential election to the conference's chosen prime minister, Nicéphore Soglo — becoming the first mainland African president to lose power through a popular election. [132] He returned to office by election in 1996. [132]

Benin moved early in a wave of reforms towards multiparty democracy across Africa at the beginning of the 1990s. [132] Not every transition succeeded, and many single-party rulers learned to survive multiparty elections. But the decade showed that the arrangement of the 1960s and 1970s was not destiny. A council

of citizens could still sit in judgement on a ruler, as the elders of Asante once had.

The Letter Principle

When power becomes greater than purpose, the letters exist to serve the hand that holds the pen. The single party, the coup and the patron all did the same thing to the grammar: they removed the rules by which letters could correct the writer. What distinguished Botswana from Zaire was not that Batswana were better people than Congolese, but that their rulers kept, and were kept by, rules that made power answerable — and that at decisive moments, men such as Seretse Khama chose to be bound by them. Institutions do not survive on goodwill alone. But they do not survive without it either. Someone, at some point, has to decide that the office is larger than the officer.

Questions for Reflection

1. Crowds in Kampala cheered the 1971 coup. Why do people sometimes welcome the fall of one ruler without asking what will replace him?
2. Nyerere built a one-party state and was also one of the few leaders of his generation to retire voluntarily. How should we weigh these two facts?
3. Mobutu's *authenticité* used African dignity to justify personal rule. Where do you see cultural pride being used today to protect people in power?
4. Thandika Mkandawire argued that "neopatrimonialism" explains too much and therefore too little. What simple explanations of African politics have you heard, and what do they leave out?
5. Seretse Khama renounced a hereditary throne and then won power by election. What would it take for leaders in your country to accept limits on their own power?

* * *

By the end of the twentieth century, Africa had lived through every arrangement of power the century could offer: kings and presidents, parties and juntas, patrons and lenders, national conferences and new constitutions. Some letters had been crushed; some had found ways to rewrite the rules.

But a deeper loss had been accumulating beneath the politics. Many Africans had learned to see their own past as a story of absence — and the achievements described in the first part of this book had come to sound, to their own descendants, like fairy tales. The next chapter asks how that happened.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 10

When Greatness Began to Sound Like a Fairy Tale

> *"The effect of the cultural bomb is to annihilate a people's belief in their names, in their languages, in their environments, in their heritage of struggle, in their unity, in their capacities and ultimately in themselves."*
>
> — Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, *Decolonising the Mind*, 1986

On 18 February 1897, British forces captured Benin City. A force of about 1,200 Royal Marines, sailors and protectorate troops had fought its way inland for ten days in three columns. In the final advance they used rockets. Oba Ovonramwen stayed in his palace until the troops were close and a rocket landed in one of its courtyards. [134]

A photograph survives from the days that followed. It shows the interior of the Oba's compound burning. In the foreground lie brass plaques — the plaques that Chapter 4 described, cast by the hereditary guild of Igun-Eronmwon to record the life of the court. Three soldiers stand in the background. [134] The plaques and heads, ivories and carvings were taken from the palace and from the homes of chiefs. Some went into the private collections of British officers. The Foreign Office sold many more, and they ended up in museums across Europe, particularly in Germany, and in the United States. The British Museum received the largest single holding, some 900 objects. [135] Ovonramwen was captured, deposed and exiled to Calabar; six chiefs were hanged in Benin City's marketplace. [134]

The objects did not stop being admired. On the contrary: their quality fetched high prices, and in 2015 a single Benin head sold to a private collector for a reported £10 million. [135] What stopped was the connection between the objects and the people who had made them. For half a century, a schoolchild in London

could see more of the recorded history of Benin than a schoolchild in Benin City.

The earlier chapters of this book described real achievements: the walls of Great Zimbabwe, the queens of Kush, the scholars of Timbuktu, the heads of Ife, the earthworks and bronzes of Benin. Many Africans grew up knowing almost nothing of them, or hearing of them, when they heard at all, as legends. How did documented greatness come to sound, to its own descendants, like a fairy tale? This chapter follows three routes: the objects that were carried away, the languages and schools that taught Africans to look elsewhere, and the scholarship that was written but did not reach the classroom.

The Plaques That Went North

The bronzes were scattered. The two largest collections are in the Ethnological Museum of Berlin and the British Museum; the third largest is in museums in Nigeria, chiefly the National Museum in Lagos. [135] Nigeria has sought their return on several occasions since independence in 1960. [135]

The story contains one of the most revealing transactions of the colonial century. Beginning in 1950, the British Museum sold more than thirty Benin plaques to the Nigerian government. Its curator, Hermann Braunholtz, had decided that of the 203 plaques the museum acquired in 1898, thirty were “duplicates” — identical representations, and so superfluous. The sales continued until 1972; the museum’s later African art specialist said he regretted them. [135] A people bought back its own history, at a price set by the institution that held it, because that institution had judged the history surplus to requirements.

What does it do to a society when its monuments and records leave? The objects themselves survive, often carefully conserved. But a plaque on a palace pillar is part of a living institution: it is seen by those who serve the king, explained by elders, renewed by the guild that cast it. A plaque in a glass case abroad is an object. The first teaches a people what it has done.

The second teaches strangers what that people once did. Over generations, the difference becomes the difference between memory and rumour.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

The British called it the “Benin Punitive Expedition.” [134] The name told a simple story, which was repeated for decades: an unarmed British party, travelling peacefully, was massacred, and the expedition was a just punishment. A simple counter-story is now common: the killing was a pretext, and the expedition was nothing but a raid for loot.

The evidence is more complicated than either. In November 1896 James Phillips, a British vice-consul in the Niger Coast Protectorate, asked London for permission to visit Benin City, arguing that the costs could be recovered through trade, including ivory. Before receiving an answer, he set off in late December with a party of about 250 people. The Oba, then celebrating the Igue festival, sent word that he did not wish to receive them and asked them to wait; Phillips went on. The Oba’s council was sharply divided; he ordered his chiefs not to attack and to let the party approach so that its intentions could be judged. On 4 January 1897, near Ugbine, Benin forces attacked anyway. Most of the British officials and many African porters were killed. [134]

The killings were real, and they were a crime against the people killed. But the historian Philip Igbafe has shown that the humanitarian and punitive justifications given for the expedition differed from the economic arguments for military action that members of the protectorate administration had been making in the months and years before. [134] British accounts emphasised human sacrifice in Benin; one surgeon’s diary describes terrible scenes as the troops approached the city. The historian Robin Law, while not denying the practice, has suggested that its reported extent was exaggerated to establish the need for

intervention. [134] And Benin was itself a kingdom that held slaves, as Chapter 4 showed. [69]

So the expedition was not simply punishment, and not simply plunder. It was a conquest that the protectorate's officials had wanted for commercial reasons, triggered by a killing that the Oba had tried to prevent, and justified to the British public in the language of humanity. The plaques taken in 1897 were not removed by accident in the confusion of war. They were part of the spoils of a planned subjugation. Naming the event accurately is the first step to understanding why the objects are now being returned.

The Language of the Classroom

Objects can be carried away. Languages are taken by other means.

The Kenyan novelist Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, who died in 2025, spent much of his life arguing that the most lasting colonial conquest was the conquest of language. In an essay published shortly after his death, he wrote: "For the colonial conqueror, it was not enough to introduce an additional language to any community. Imperial languages had to be planted on the graveyard of the languages of the dominated." He recalled what he had described in *Decolonising the Mind* (1986): "the corporal punishment meted out to African children caught speaking an African language at school, children who were then made to carry a placard around the neck proclaiming their stupidity. In some cases, the culprit was made to swallow filth, thus associating African languages with criminality, pain and filth." [136]

In *Decolonising the Mind* he called this a "cultural bomb," whose effect was to make a people see their past as "wastelands of non-achievement" and to want to distance themselves from it. [137] That phrase explains the title of this chapter. A child punished for speaking her mother's language learns that what her mother knows is worthless. A child taught that history

happened elsewhere learns that her ancestors did nothing worth recording. Neither lesson needs to be stated. It is carried by the arrangement of the classroom.

Colonial education also had political purposes. In Tanganyika, the British administration encouraged the education of chiefs' sons, believing it would help to perpetuate the system of chiefs and prevent the emergence of a separate educated elite who might challenge colonial rule. [122] The plan failed in at least one famous case: one of those chiefs' sons was Julius Nyerere.

Ngũgĩ's solution was radical. He renounced English for his fiction and wrote it in Gikuyu, and he argued to the end of his life that "all languages are treasuries of history, beauty and possibility." [136][137] He did not keep his vow entirely: he returned to writing criticism in English. Other writers, Salman Rushdie among them, have stressed that English and French are too useful to abandon. [137] The debate is still open. What is not in doubt is the injury he described.

[AUTHOR: What did your school teach you about Africa, and about Europe? Which kingdoms, inventors, explorers and empires appeared in your textbooks — and which did not? Was Luganda or any other Ugandan language punished or discouraged at school? When did you first learn about Great Zimbabwe, Timbuktu or Benin, and how did it feel? (Interview questions 6 and 8.)]

A History on the Shelf

Chapter 1 told how, in 1964, the year after an Oxford professor declared on the radio that Africa had no history, UNESCO launched the *General History of Africa*, drawing on hundreds of African and international scholars and approaching the continent's past from African perspectives. [16] It was completed in 1999. UNESCO's director-general later called it "a revolution in the recognition of Africa's cultural heritage." [138]

It was also, for years, barely read outside universities. A report in *The Guardian* in 2010 observed that the political climate

had changed, “with pan-Africanism being overtaken by hard-line nationalism, so the tomes gathered dust on the shelves of government offices.” [139] The history had been written. It had not been taught.

In 2009, with the backing of the African Union and $2 million in funding from Libya, UNESCO began a second phase: to turn the scholarly volumes into common teaching materials for African schools. In June 2010, a conference in Tripoli brought together 150 historians, education specialists and officials to plan a historical atlas, teaching resources and training for history teachers. [138][139] Whether those materials reach a given classroom depends, still, on the decisions of each country’s ministry of education.

This is the third route by which greatness became a fairy tale, and the one most fully in African hands. The objects were taken by others. The languages were suppressed by others. But the decision about what independent Africa’s children would learn about their past belonged, after independence, to independent African governments. How well they made it is a question every reader can test against their own schooling.

Coming Home

Chapter 2 promised to return to what it means when the monuments of a people come home.

In 1937, during the Italian occupation of Ethiopia, the great stele of Aksum was cut into pieces and shipped to Rome as a spoil of war. In 1947 Italy agreed, in a United Nations agreement, to return it. It came home only in April 2005, and was re-erected at Aksum in 2008. [38][140] Fifty-eight years passed between the promise and the delivery.

The Benin bronzes have begun to move more quickly. In October 2021 Jesus College, Cambridge, announced that it would return a bronze cockerel, the *Okukor*, after its students raised the question of its origin. [135] In July 2022 Germany signed a joint declaration to restitute some 1,130 Benin objects

held in its public museums. In October 2022 the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of African Art signed over ownership of 29 bronzes to Nigeria's National Commission for Museums and Monuments, and in November 2022 the Horniman Museum in London became the first British museum to return bronzes. The British Museum's collection of some 900 objects remains protected by an act of Parliament. [135]

Return has raised its own questions. In March 2023 Nigeria's outgoing president, Muhammadu Buhari, decreed that all repatriated Benin objects belong to the royal family of Benin, and the Oba announced plans for a museum near his palace; the new Museum of West African Art in Benin City, partly funded by Germany, opened in 2024 without bronzes. [135] An American reparations group representing descendants of enslaved Africans petitioned against returns from Britain, arguing that African rulers had been complicit in selling captives into the Atlantic trade and that the descendants of the enslaved also had a claim. [135] Chapter 4 showed that the brass itself came largely from manillas, the currency of that trade. [74] The objects carry all of their history home with them.

None of this is a reason to keep them abroad. It is a reason to be honest about what restitution can do. Returning a plaque to Benin City does not by itself restore the knowledge that went with it. That requires museums that are open, schools that teach, guilds that still cast, and citizens who visit. A homecoming is the beginning of a sentence, not the end of one.

The Letter Principle

A letter that does not know its own shape will accept whatever place it is given. That is why the loss described in this chapter matters more than any single object. When a people's achievements are removed to other countries, when its children are punished for its languages, and when its own scholarship gathers dust, it begins to believe that greatness belongs to others and that its own past is a story of absence. Restoring that

knowledge is not nostalgia. It is a precondition for any new arrangement. People who believe their ancestors could build, govern, trade and write can imagine building again. People who believe their ancestors did nothing will wait for someone else to write the sentence.

Questions for Reflection

1. A child in London in 1950 could see Benin's plaques; a child in Benin City could not. What objects or records of your own community's history are kept far from the people they belong to?
2. The British Museum sold "duplicate" plaques back to Nigeria. What does it mean when one party decides which parts of another's history are surplus?
3. Ngũgĩ described children punished for speaking African languages at school. Which languages were encouraged and discouraged in your schooling, and with what effect?
4. The *General History of Africa* was written but, for years, not taught. Who decides what history young people in your country learn, and how could you influence it?
5. Restitution has raised questions about who should own returned objects and what they mean. If a looted object from your community came home, where should it go, and who should decide?

* * *

The walls of Great Zimbabwe, the scholars of Timbuktu, the plaques of Benin: none of them was a fairy tale. They became one when the evidence was carried away, the languages silenced and the books left unread. They can stop being one when the evidence is returned, the languages honoured and the books opened.

The final chapter of this book gathers every layer together — the ecology and the kingdoms, the markets of captivity and the

lines of conquest, the inherited machinery and the choices made with it — and asks what sentence we have inherited, and who now holds the pen.

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

Chapter 11

The Sentence We Inherited

> *"One is when midnight comes; the clock strikes, and you are independent. Fine. But then begins a whole process of changing conditions and changing people."*
>
> — Julius Nyerere

On 14 April 2026, in a ceremony at the Iziko South African Museum in Cape Town, South Africa's Minister of Sport, Arts and Culture, Gayton McKenzie, handed over a carved soapstone bird and the remains of Zimbabwean ancestors to the Republic of Zimbabwe. The next day President Emmerson Mnangagwa received them at State House in Harare. South Africa's heritage agency announced that the bird had come home "after 137 years." [141]

This book began in the valley where that bird once stood. In 1889 a hunter named Willi Posselt, who had heard of Great Zimbabwe from Karl Mauch, climbed to the highest part of the ruins, though he was told it was a sacred place he should not enter. There he found a group of carved birds set on pillars around what seemed to be an altar. He paid a local man with blankets and "some other articles," hacked one bird from its pedestal because the whole was too heavy to carry, and later sold it to Cecil Rhodes, who mounted it in the library of his Cape Town house, Groote Schuur. [142] Rhodes's interest led him to sponsor the excavations of Theodore Bent, which Chapter 1 described; Bent counted eight birds. [142][4] At least five of them ended up in South Africa. [142]

The birds came home in stages, and each stage tells its own story. In 1981, a year after Zimbabwe's independence, South Africa returned four of them in exchange for a collection of insects held in Harare. [142] In 2003 a museum in Berlin returned the lower part of a pedestal that had travelled to Germany. [142] The last bird, Rhodes's own, stayed at Groote Schuur until 2026.

[141][142] Even then, the official account records that South Africa approved only its "temporary relocation pending legislative processes." [141] The bird is home; the law has not yet finished catching up. Meanwhile the same bird had flown for more than a century on the flags and coins of Rhodesia and then of Zimbabwe. [142][9]

Mauch saw the walls in 1871 and told the wrong story. A century and a half later, the story is being corrected in a museum hall in Cape Town, a State House in Harare and a legislative process not yet complete. The walls never moved. The arrangements around them — laws, borders, collections, governments — had to be changed by people, slowly, one decision at a time.

That is the argument of this final chapter. The first ten chapters followed the letters through many centuries: the builders and their burdens, the markets of captivity, the lines of conquest, the inherited machinery, the power that outgrew its purpose and the memory that faded into fairy tale. What sentence did all of this leave us, and who now holds the pen?

The Question on Campus

[AUTHOR: Return to the scene that began the book — the campus, the year, and the question you asked then about why Africa seemed "dark and far from civilisation." What did you believe then? (Interview questions 1, 2 and 4.)]

[AUTHOR: How has researching and writing *Origins* changed your answer? What do you now see that you did not see on campus? (Interview question 5.)]

Layers, Not a Villain

The answer this book offers is not a single cause. It is a set of layers, each laid down at a different time, each pressing on the ones above it, none of them the whole story.

The land. Across much of Africa, land was abundant and people were few, so rulers competed to control people rather

than territory, and borders stayed vague. [85] In zones where the tsetse fly made it hard to keep draught animals, farming produced smaller surpluses and political centralisation was less common. [86] Geography did not decide history. It set the terms on which history was made.

African state-building and its costs. Africans built states, cities and civilisations of many kinds: the sacred hill of Mapungubwe, the merchant towns of the Swahili coast, the kingdoms of Mali, Benin, Buganda and Asante, and assemblies without kings among the Igbo. [59][62][75][81][82] They also built hierarchies, armies and markets in captives. [61][75][81] The arrangements of power made in those centuries still shape where development is easiest today. [87]

The markets of captivity. The slave trades took millions of people across the Atlantic, the Sahara and the Indian Ocean, and the Atlantic trade alone carried some 12.5 million. [90][93] Where the trades were heaviest, economies are poorer today, and trust in neighbours, relatives and local government is lower. [91][92] Before a letter could fear the stranger, it learned to fear the neighbour.

Conquest and borders. European conquest drew borders over three decades of treaties and wars, often along existing frontiers but sometimes dividing peoples, with lasting costs for those who were split. [100][101] It rewrote land, tax and authority, as the Buganda agreement of 1900 did at a stroke. [98]

Colonial institutions. Indirect rule made chiefs answerable upwards to colonial officers rather than downwards to their people, and where there were no chiefs it invented them. [102] [107] Colonial economies were built to export, and colonial armies to keep order. [108][119]

Independence choices. The new states inherited this machinery, and then made choices with it. In 1964 they pledged to keep the borders they had inherited. [115] Some abolished kingdoms by force; some dismantled chiefdoms by policy; some made themselves one-party states. [112][122][110]

The international system. The Cold War rewarded rulers who controlled capitals and chose the right side, and kept men like Mobutu in power for decades. [124][127] The debt crisis brought structural adjustment, and with it economic decisions negotiated with distant lenders. [133]

Leadership. Within all these constraints, particular people made particular decisions. Amin chose terror; Seretse Khama chose to renounce a throne and be bound by elections; Kérékou chose not to turn his soldiers on a national conference. [123][131] [132] The same inheritance produced different sentences in different hands.

Memory. Over everything lay a loss of memory: objects carried away, languages punished in classrooms, and scholarship left on shelves, until Africa's documented achievements sounded to many Africans like fairy tales. [135] [136][139]

No single layer explains the present. Together they explain a great deal. And each layer has a date, which means each was made — and what was made can, with effort, be remade.

When the Evidence Corrects the Story

The most popular explanations of Africa's condition are single causes. One says: colonialism did it. Another says: corrupt leaders did it. A third, older and uglier, says: something in African culture did it. Each is repeated because it is simple, and because it assigns blame to someone other than the speaker.

The research described in this book does not support any of them on its own. It supports all of the layers at once. Nathan Nunn found lasting effects from the slave trades, which began centuries before colonial rule. [91] Stelios Michalopoulos and Elias Papaioannou found that precolonial political institutions still predict where economic activity is concentrated — and, separately, that the borders of the Scramble left partitioned peoples worse off. [87][101] Marcella Alsan traced part of the pattern of centralisation to an insect. [86] James Robinson,

reviewing Jeffrey Herbst, argued that European expansion from the fifteenth century mattered more than population density. [85] Daron Acemoglu, Simon Johnson and James Robinson explained Botswana's success by inclusive precolonial institutions, light colonial rule, diamond revenues and, crucially, the decisions of its leaders. [129] Thandika Mkandawire warned that a label used to explain everything explains nothing. [128]

These findings do not contradict one another. They stack. And all of them describe tendencies, not fates. The studies measure averages across many societies; Botswana and Benin are reminders that a society can depart from the average when its people and leaders choose to. [129][132]

The single-cause stories fail for a further reason. Each of them, followed to its end, removes African agency. If colonialism did everything, Africans did nothing. If leaders did everything, citizens did nothing. If culture did everything, no one could have done otherwise. The evidence of this book points the other way. At every layer there were Africans making choices — Afonso writing to Lisbon, the women of Oloko sitting on the warrant chiefs, the Lukiiko voting, the librarians of Timbuktu carrying manuscripts by night. [88][107][112][56] A history without villains is not a history without responsibility. It is a history in which responsibility is shared, unequally, and in which there is always someone who could have written a different sentence.

What History Does Not Decide

History explains the arrangement we inherited. It does not decide the arrangement we must keep.

This is not wishful thinking. It is what the record shows. The Golden Stool was kept from a governor who demanded it, because the Asante had decided long before that the nation's soul was larger than any king. [80] Botswana kept its kgotla and placed it under the law of a democratic state. [130] Benin's citizens sat in judgement on a military ruler, and he accepted it. [132] South Africa returned a bird that Cecil Rhodes had kept in

his library. [141][142] None of these choices was forced by history. Each was made by people who decided that the old arrangement would not be the final one.

It also works the other way. The habits formed by the markets of captivity, the conquest and the single party did not end when the conditions that produced them ended. Mistrust outlived the slave trades. [92] Inherited borders became chosen borders. [115] Armies that learned in 1966 that the gun decides went on deciding. [112][123] What is no longer imposed can still be repeated. That is the hardest part of the inheritance: the sentences we keep writing out of habit, long after anyone is forcing our hand.

[AUTHOR: An example from your own life or work — as a founder or a minister — of an inherited arrangement that no one now imposes, but that people still repeat. (Interview questions 9, 10 and 11.)]

The Letter Principle

People are the letters. Institutions are the grammar. Shared progress is the sentence. This book has tried to show where the grammar of African societies came from: some of it built by Africans with brilliance and cruelty, some imposed by others with force and contempt, some inherited and kept by choice. It has also tried to keep faith with the limits of the image. No person is merely a letter in someone else's sentence; every one keeps their dignity when the grammar fails them; and the word *Africa* has always needed different letters, never identical ones. The grammar was made by people, and people can remake it. That work does not begin with blame. It begins with the question every chapter of this book has asked of every arrangement: how did it work, and what did it require people to endure?

Questions for Reflection

1. Of the layers described in this chapter — land, state-building, the slave trades, conquest, colonial institutions,

independence choices, the international system, leadership and memory — which do you think weighs most heavily on your own community today, and why?

2. Which single-cause explanation of Africa's problems have you heard most often? What does this book suggest it leaves out?
3. The last Zimbabwe Bird came home in 2026 as a "temporary relocation pending legislative processes." Where in your society has the law not yet caught up with a decision already made?
4. Name one inherited arrangement in your family, church, school, business or country that no one now imposes, but that people still repeat. What would it take to change it?
5. After reading *Origins*, what has changed in how you see the African past — and in how you see your own responsibility for the African future?

* * *

The walls are still standing in their valley, and the bird has come home. Neither needed us to worship it. Both needed us to read them honestly, and then to decide what to build.

This book has asked how we got here. The next asks what we are doing now: how the inherited grammar shows up in the offices, markets, churches, campuses and families of contemporary Africa, and why so many people of ability find their efforts scattered. History placed some letters badly. But history is no longer holding every hand. So why are we still writing some of the same sentences?

The letters remain. The question is the sentence.

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Chapter 5 · The Grammar of African Power

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Chapter 6 · The Markets of Captivity

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Chapter 10 · When Greatness Began to Sound Like a Fairy Tale

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